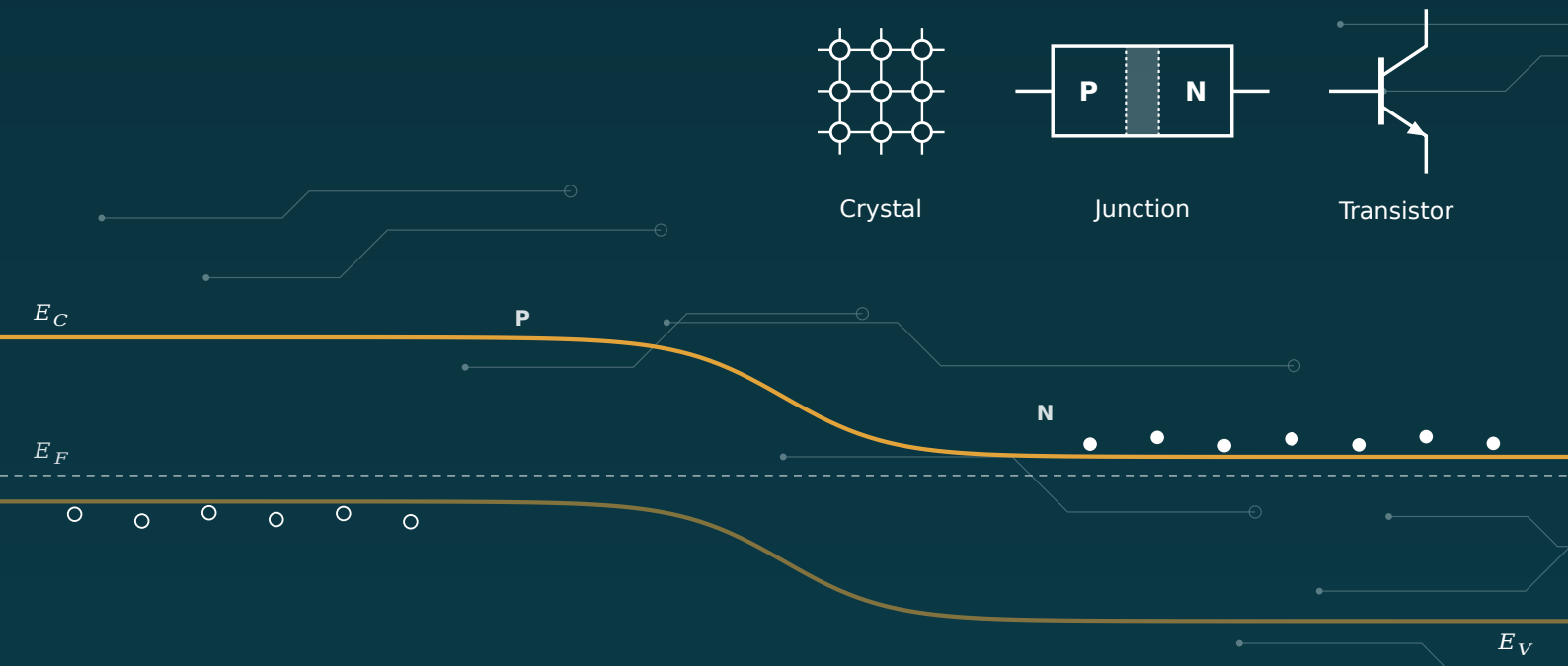
NATIONAL SCHOOL OF ENGINEERS OF SOUSSE (ENISO)
Department of Industrial Electronics



EXERCISES

Semiconductor Devices Physics

Problems for Chapters 0 to 8, with hints and key results

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ACADEMIC YEAR
2026/2027

Chapters 0 to 8: why semiconductor devices? · transport phenomena · semiconductors at equilibrium · energy bands and the Fermi level · carriers out of equilibrium · the PN junction at and out of equilibrium · the capacitances of the junction · the bipolar junction transistor

How to use this collection

One set per chapter. Each chapter of the course has a set of problems, numbered by chapter: Problem 3.4 is the fourth problem of the Chapter 3 set. A set uses only what has been taught up to the end of its chapter; the box at the start of each set says which ideas it calls on and which data it uses.

Three levels. Within a set the problems are arranged in order of difficulty, and each one carries a label:

- **A · Understanding**: reasoning with the physical picture, orders of magnitude, short arguments. No long calculation.
- **B · Guided calculation**: a calculation in several steps, set out in the order in which the course builds the result.
- **C · Synthesis**: problems that combine several ideas, ask for a derivation, or apply the course to a situation it did not treat explicitly.

Hints. Many problems have a hint. It tells you where to start or which idea to use; it does not give the result. Try the problem first without it.

Figures. Figures placed with a statement show the device or the set-up; they appear in both documents. Figures inside a solution show the result, a profile, a curve or a band diagram, and appear only in the worked solutions. Curves are computed with the numbers of the solution; pictures labelled 'generic' show shapes, not values. A figure marked 'After Neamen, Fig. …' or 'After Sze & Lee, Fig. …' is redrawn from that textbook figure.

Sources. Under the title of each problem, a line gives its origin. *Original problem* means that the problem was written for this course. *Adapted from Neamen, Problem n, p. p* or *Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. c, Problem n, p. p* means that the problem starts from that textbook problem; it has been rewritten for the course, usually with the data of the course, more explicit assumptions and additional questions, so that its numbers differ from those of the book. The two textbooks are

- D. A. Neamen, *Semiconductor Physics and Devices: Basic Principles*, 4th ed., McGraw-Hill, 2012;
- S. M. Sze and M. K. Lee, *Semiconductor Devices: Physics and Technology*, 3rd ed., Wiley, 2012.

Page numbers are the printed page numbers of these editions.

Numbers. Give results with two or three significant figures, and always with their units. When a result looks surprising, check its order of magnitude before going on: many problems ask you to compare a computed value with another one, and that comparison is usually the point of the problem.

Data used throughout

Unless a problem states otherwise, the material is silicon at $T = 300$ K and the values below are used. They are the values of the course.

Quantity	Value	Remark
Elementary charge	$q = 1.602 \times 10^{-19}$ C	$q > 0$; electron charge $-q$
Electron mass	$m_0 = 9.11 \times 10^{-31}$ kg	
Boltzmann constant	$k = 1.381 \times 10^{-23}$ J/K $= 8.617 \times 10^{-5}$ eV/K	
Thermal energy, thermal voltage	$kT = 25.9$ meV, $V_T = kT/q = 25.9$ mV	at 300 K
Planck constant	$h = 6.626 \times 10^{-34}$ J·s, $hc = 1240$ eV·nm	
Vacuum permittivity	$\varepsilon_0 = 8.854 \times 10^{-14}$ F/cm	
Silicon permittivity	$\varepsilon = 11.7\,\varepsilon_0 = 1.036 \times 10^{-12}$ F/cm	
Atoms of silicon	5×10^{22} cm^{-3}	
Gap of silicon	$E_g = 1.12$ eV	
Intrinsic density of silicon	$n_i = 10^{10}$ cm^{-3}	reference value of the course
Effective densities of states	$N_C = 2.8 \times 10^{19}$, $N_V = 1.04 \times 10^{19}$ cm^{-3}	
Mobilities (low doping)	$\mu_n = 1350$, $\mu_p = 460$ cm²/(V·s)	
Diffusion coefficients	$D_n = 35$, $D_p = 12$ cm²/s	Einstein relation

Reference devices. The *reference junction* of Chapters 5 to 7 is an abrupt silicon P$^+$N junction with $N_A = 10^{18}$ cm^{-3} and $N_D = 10^{16}$ cm^{-3}, built-in voltage $V_d = 0.835$ V and equilibrium SCR width $W = 0.330$ µm. As a diode it has short neutral regions, $d_p = 2$ µm and $d_n = 10$ µm, minority lifetimes $\tau_n = 0.1$ µs and $\tau_p = 10$ µs, an area $S = 10^{-4}$ cm², and $J_0 = 2.2 \times 10^{-11}$ A/cm². The *reference transistor* of Chapter 8 is an NPN transistor with $N_E = 10^{18}$, $N_B = 10^{16}$ and $N_C = 10^{15}$ cm^{-3}, neutral widths $d_E = 0.5$ µm, $W_B = 1.0$ µm (at $V_{CB} = 5$ V) and $d_C = 10$ µm, and area $S = 10^{-4}$ cm²; its main parameters are recalled at the start of the Chapter 8 set.

Mobilities in doped material. The mobilities fall when the doping rises. The course uses the low-doping values above throughout, as a simplification; when a problem needs another value, the problem gives it.

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SEMICONDUCTOR DEVICES PHYSICS · EXERCISES

CHAPTER 0

Why Semiconductor Devices?

WHAT THIS SET USES

The building blocks of devices, the history from the vacuum tube to the integrated circuit, the two device laws quoted in the chapter (Child–Langmuir and Shockley), Moore's law and scaling, lithography. Neither textbook has problems on these topics: this set is original, and is a set of estimates rather than of physics.

DATA

$hc = 1240$ eV·nm, $\varepsilon_0 = 8.854\times10^{-12}$ F/m, $q = 1.602\times10^{-19}$ C, $m_0 = 9.11\times10^{-31}$ kg; silicon: 5×10^{22} atoms/cm³, density 2.33 g/cm³; $V_T = 25.9$ mV.

Problem 0.1 Four building blocks

A · Understanding

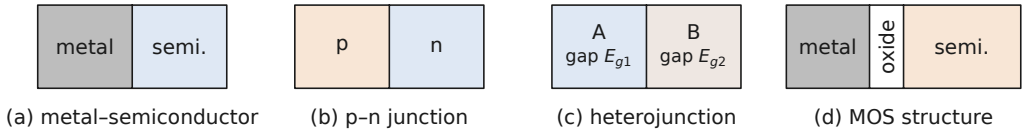
Original problem

The chapter claims that almost every device is one of four building blocks, metal–semiconductor contact, p–n junction, heterojunction, metal–oxide–semiconductor (MOS) structure, or a combination of them.

(a) Classify the following devices: silicon solar cell; Schottky diode; bipolar junction transistor; MOS transistor; GaN blue LED (whose active layer is a thin InGaN layer between GaN layers); heterojunction bipolar transistor.

(b) For the MOS transistor and the bipolar transistor, say which block appears more than once and how many times.

(c) The course studies the p–n junction and the bipolar transistor in detail. Using your answer to (a), explain why this choice already covers part of the physics of the MOS transistor.



(a) metal–semiconductor (b) p–n junction (c) heterojunction (d) MOS structure

The four building blocks of semiconductor devices.

HINT

A device is a combination of blocks when it contains several interfaces of different kinds; count the interfaces a carrier crosses.

(Answer: (a) p–n; metal–semiconductor; two p–n; MOS + two p–n; heterojunctions (+ p–n); heterojunction + p–n. (b) BJT: p–n twice; MOS transistor: p–n twice (source, drain) around one MOS structure.)

Problem 0.2 Moore's law in numbers **B · Guided calculation**

Original problem

The first microprocessor (1971) contained about 2300 transistors. A large processor chip of the early 2020s contains of the order of 5×10^{10} transistors.

(a) Assume that the number of transistors per chip doubles every two years from 1971. How many transistors would a chip of 2021 contain?

(b) Which doubling time is implied by the two data points (1971 and 2021)?

(c) By how much does the number of transistors grow each year, in percent, for a doubling time of 2 years?

(d) The chapter says that Moore's law is 'an industrial roadmap, not a law of physics'. Give one argument from your results that supports this statement.

> **HINT**
> After t years with a doubling time T_2, the number is multiplied by $2^{t/T_2}$. To find T_2 from two values, take the base-2 logarithm of their ratio.

(Answer: (a) 7.7×10^{10}; (b) 2.05 years; (c) 41 % per year.)

Problem 0.3 How much of Moore's law is shrinking? **B · Guided calculation**

Original problem

The minimum feature size went from about 10 µm in 1971 to about 20 nm around 2015 (Chapter 0, figure of scaling).

(a) By what factor did the feature size L decrease, and by what factor per year, on average?

(b) The area of a transistor scales as L^2. By what factor did the number of transistors per unit area increase? What doubling time of the density does this correspond to?

(c) Compare with the doubling time of about 2 years of Problem 0.2. What else must have grown to make up the difference?

> **HINT**
> Treat the decrease as geometric: a constant factor per year.

(Answer: (a) factor 500, i.e. ×0.868 per year (−13 %/year); (b) factor 2.5×10^5, doubling every 2.45 years; (c) the area of the chip and the efficiency of the layout.)

Problem 0.4 Light for lithography **B · Guided calculation**

Original problem

The chapter states that the smallest pattern that light can print is of the order of λ/NA, where NA is the numerical aperture of the optics.

(a) Compute the photon energy, in eV, of the mercury line at 365 nm, of the ArF excimer laser at 193 nm and of EUV light at 13.5 nm. Compare each with the gap of silicon, 1.12 eV.

(b) Estimate λ/NA for 193 nm light through water with NA = 1.35, and for EUV light with NA = 0.33.

(c) The tightest metal pitch of a '3 nm' process is about 20–25 nm. Which of the two techniques of (b) can print it in a single exposure?

(d) The chapter says that EUV light is absorbed by air and by glass. Use your result of (a) to explain why such light is absorbed by nearly every material.

> **HINT**
> $E = hc/\lambda$ with $hc = 1240$ eV·nm.

(Answer: (a) 3.40, 6.42 and 91.9 eV, i.e. 3, 6 and 82 times E_g; (b) 143 nm and 41 nm; (c) lines of 10–12 nm: immersion is more than 10 times too coarse, EUV within a factor of 2 to 4; (d) 92 eV exceeds the binding energies of the outer electrons of all atoms.)

Problem 0.5 Two device laws

B · Guided calculation

Original problem

The chapter quotes two laws: the Child–Langmuir law of the vacuum diode, $J = \frac{4\varepsilon_0}{9}\sqrt{\frac{2q}{m}}\frac{V^{3/2}}{d^2}$, and the Shockley law of the junction diode, $I = I_s[\exp(V/\eta V_T) - 1]$.

(a) Compute J for a vacuum diode with $d = 1$ mm and $V = 100$ V. What current flows through a plate of 1 cm²?

(b) By what factor does the current of the vacuum diode increase when V is doubled?

(c) For the junction diode ($\eta = 1$, well above V_T), by how much must V increase to multiply the current by 10? By 2.83?

(d) Compare the voltages involved in the two devices, and comment on the advantage of the junction diode for low-voltage electronics.

> **HINT**
> Work in SI units in (a). In (c), for $V \gg V_T$, $I \simeq I_s e^{V/V_T}$, so a factor r on the current needs $\Delta V = V_T \ln r$.

(Answer: (a) $J = 2.3 \times 10^3$ A/m² = 0.23 A/cm², 0.23 A; (b) $2^{3/2} = 2.83$; (c) 59.6 mV, 26.9 mV.)

> **Challenge: a new situation**
> These problems apply the method of the chapter to a device, a material or a situation that the chapter did not treat. The reasoning does not change: state the physical picture, choose the model, compute, check.

Problem 0.6 From a wafer to a chip, and why not tubes

C · Synthesis

Original problem

A 300 mm silicon wafer is 0.775 mm thick. It carries square chips of 1 cm², each holding 5×10^{10} transistors.

(a) How many silicon atoms does the wafer contain, and what is its mass?

(b) The number of whole chips on a wafer of diameter D is estimated by $N \simeq \pi D^2/(4A) - \pi D/\sqrt{2A}$, where A is the chip area; the second term counts the chips lost at the edge. Evaluate N.

(c) The transistors are built in the top micrometre of the silicon. How many silicon atoms of this layer are there per transistor on one chip?

(d) Suppose that each of the switches of one chip were a vacuum tube whose filament needs only 1 W. What power would the chip need? A modern processor dissipates of the order of 100 W: what power does that leave per transistor?

> **HINT**
> In (c), the volume of the layer under one chip is 1 cm² × 1 µm.

(Answer: (a) 2.7×10^{24} atoms, 128 g; (b) about 640 chips; (c) 10^8 atoms per transistor; (d) 5×10^{10} W = 50 GW, against 2 nW per transistor.)

SEMICONDUCTOR DEVICES PHYSICS · EXERCISES

CHAPTER 1

Transport Phenomena: Drift, Diffusion and Continuity

WHAT THIS SET USES

The current density $J = q\,n\,v$; the Drude model, $v_d = q\tau_c\mathcal{E}/m^*$ and $\mu = q\tau_c/m^*$; the thermal velocity; the diffusion flux $-D\,\mathrm{d}n/\mathrm{d}x$; the Einstein relation $D = \mu\,kT/q$; the total currents $J_n = q\mu_n n\mathcal{E} + qD_n\,\mathrm{d}n/\mathrm{d}x$ and $J_p = q\mu_p p\mathcal{E} - qD_p\,\mathrm{d}p/\mathrm{d}x$; the continuity equation without generation or recombination.

DATA

Silicon electrons: conductivity effective mass $m^* = 0.26\,m_0$. $kT/q = 25.9$ mV at 300 K. Other data from the data sheet at the front.

Problem 1.1 From a drift velocity to a collision time

B · Guided calculation

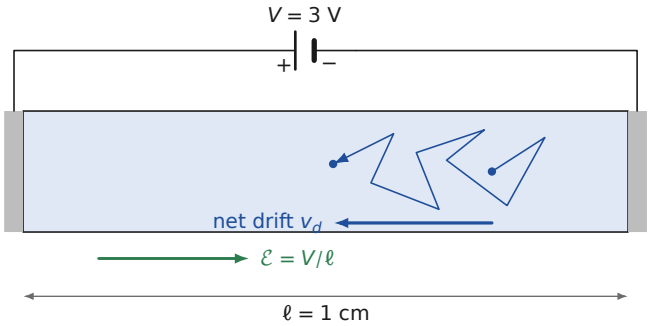
Adapted from Neamen, Problem 5.10, p. 185

A voltage of 3 V is applied across a semiconductor bar 1 cm long. The electrons acquire an average drift velocity of 10^4 cm/s.

(a) What is the field in the bar, assumed uniform? Deduce the electron mobility.

(b) With the Drude relation $\mu = q\tau_c/m^*$, find the mean time between collisions, taking $m^* = 0.26\,m_0$.

(c) In another material the electron mobility is 800 cm²/(V·s). What drift velocity does the same voltage produce? By what factor is τ_c shorter, for the same m^*?



Random flights between collisions, with a small net drift of the electrons against the field.

HINT

Convert the mobility to m²/(V·s) before using $\tau_c = \mu m^*/q$ in SI units.

(Answer: (a) 3 V/cm, $\mu = 3.3\times10^3$ cm²/(V·s); (b) $\tau_c = 0.49$ ps; (c) 2.4×10^3 cm/s, 4.2 times shorter.)

Problem 1.2 How much energy does drift give an electron? B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 5.20, p. 186

Electrons in silicon at 300 K have $\mu_n = 1350$ cm²/(V·s) and $m^* = 0.26\,m_0$. The Drude model assumes that the field only adds a small drift to a fast random thermal motion.

(a) Compute the drift velocity and the kinetic energy of the drift motion, $\frac{1}{2}m^*v_d^2$, for $\mathcal{E} = 10$ V/cm and for $\mathcal{E} = 1$ kV/cm.

(b) Compute the thermal velocity $v_{th} = \sqrt{3kT/m^*}$ and the mean thermal kinetic energy $\frac{3}{2}kT$.

(c) Compare. Up to what order of magnitude of field can the assumption of the Drude model, $v_d \ll v_{th}$, be considered safe?

> **HINT**
> Work in SI units and convert the energies to eV by dividing by q.

(Answer: (a) 1.35×10^4 cm/s and 1.3×10^{-8} eV; 1.35×10^6 cm/s and 1.3×10^{-4} eV; (b) 2.3×10^7 cm/s, 38.8 meV; (c) $v_d/v_{th} = 0.06$ at 1 kV/cm: safe up to a few kV/cm.)

Problem 1.3 Several kinds of collisions B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 5.24, p. 187

In a semiconductor several scattering mechanisms act at the same time (vibrations of the lattice, ionised impurities, …). Each one, alone, would give a collision time τ_i and a mobility $\mu_i = q\tau_i/m^*$.

(a) The mechanisms are independent: in a short time $\mathrm{d}t$, the probability of a collision of type i is $\mathrm{d}t/\tau_i$. Show that the total collision rate is $1/\tau_c = \sum_i 1/\tau_i$, and deduce that $1/\mu = \sum_i 1/\mu_i$ (Matthiessen's rule).

(b) Three mechanisms alone would give 2000, 1500 and 500 cm²/(V·s). What is the mobility? Which mechanism controls it?

(c) Two mechanisms alone would give 250 and 500 cm²/(V·s) (Sze & Lee, Ch. 2, Problem 3, p. 79). What is the mobility?

> **HINT**
> Probabilities of independent, rare events in the same short interval add.

(Answer: (b) 316 cm²/(V·s), controlled by the 500 cm²/(V·s) mechanism; (c) 167 cm²/(V·s).)

Problem 1.4 Mobility, diffusion and temperature B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 5.25, p. 187

The electron mobility of a silicon sample is 1300 cm²/(V·s) at 300 K. It is limited by the vibrations of the lattice, and then varies as $T^{-3/2}$.

(a) Explain in one sentence, with the Drude picture, why the mobility falls when the temperature rises.

(b) Compute the mobility at 200 K and at 400 K.

(c) Compute the diffusion coefficient at 200, 300 and 400 K with the Einstein relation. How does D vary with T?

> **HINT**
> $kT/q = 25.9 \times (T/300)$ mV.

(Answer: (b) 2390 and 844 cm²/(V·s); (c) 41.2, 33.7, 29.2 cm²/s: $D \propto T^{-1/2}$.)

Problem 1.5 Two diffusion currents — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problems 5.31 and 5.34, p. 188

Use $D_p = 12$ cm²/s and $D_n = 35$ cm²/s.

(a) The hole density in a silicon sample is $p(x) = 5 \times 10^{15}\,\mathrm{e}^{-x/L_p}$ cm^{-3} for $x \geq 0$, with $L_p = 50$ µm. Compute the hole flux and the hole diffusion current density at $x = 0$ and at $x = L_p$. In which direction do the holes move, and in which direction does the current flow?

(b) The electron diffusion current density in another sample is uniform, $J_n = 2$ A/cm², and $n(0) = 10^{15}$ cm^{-3}. What is the shape of $n(x)$? Compute n at $x = 20$ µm. Do the electrons move towards $+x$ or $-x$?

(c) In (a) the current varies with x, in (b) it does not. Using the continuity equation, say what would happen to the hole density in case (a) if nothing else acted on the holes. (Chapter 4 adds the missing process.)

> **HINT**
> Flux $\Phi = -D\,\mathrm{d}n/\mathrm{d}x$; current of holes $q\Phi_p$, of electrons $-q\Phi_n$.

(Answer: (a) $J_p(0) = 1.92$ A/cm², $J_p(L_p) = 0.71$ A/cm², both towards $+x$; (b) linear, $n(20\ \mu\mathrm{m}) = 1.71 \times 10^{15}$ cm^{-3}, electrons move towards $-x$.)

Problem 1.6 Drift and diffusion share one current — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 2, Problem 16, p. 80

In a silicon sample the total current density is constant, $J = 4.8$ A/cm², and is the sum of an electron drift current and a hole diffusion current. The electron density is uniform, $n = 10^{16}$ cm^{-3}, and the holes have $p(x) = 10^{15}\,\mathrm{e}^{-x/L}$ cm^{-3} for $x \geq 0$, with $L = 12$ µm. Take $\mu_n = 1350$ cm²/(V·s) and $D_p = 12$ cm²/s.

(a) Compute the hole diffusion current density $J_p(x)$.

(b) Deduce the electron current density $J_n(x)$.

(c) Deduce the field $\mathcal{E}(x)$ and its values at $x = 0$ and far from the origin. Why can the electron diffusion current and the hole drift current be neglected?

> **HINT**
> The total current is the same at every x; what one carrier loses, the other gains.

(Answer: (a) $J_p = 1.60\,\mathrm{e}^{-x/L}$ A/cm²; (b) $J_n = 4.8 - 1.60\,\mathrm{e}^{-x/L}$ A/cm²; (c) $\mathcal{E}(0) = 1.48$ V/cm, $\mathcal{E}(\infty) = 2.22$ V/cm.)

Problem 1.7 A field without a current

B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 5.40, p. 189

An n-type sample is in thermal equilibrium, with no current. Its electron density follows the donors, $n(x) = N_0\,\mathrm{e}^{-x/L}$ for $0 \le x \le L$, with $N_0 = 10^{16}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$ and $L = 10$ µm.

(a) In equilibrium $J_n = 0$. Write J_n as the sum of its drift and diffusion terms and show, with the Einstein relation, that $\mathcal{E}(x) = -\dfrac{kT}{q}\dfrac{1}{n}\dfrac{\mathrm{d}n}{\mathrm{d}x}$.

(b) Compute $\mathcal{E}$ for the exponential profile. In which direction does it point, and why must it point that way?

(c) Compute the potential difference between $x = 0$ and $x = L$. Which end is at the higher potential?

(d) Does a voltmeter connected between the two ends read this voltage? Answer with an argument about equilibrium.

> **HINT**
> The field must push the electrons back up the gradient, against diffusion.

(Answer: (b) $\mathcal{E} = kT/(qL) = 25.9$ V/cm along $+x$; (c) $V(0) - V(L) = 25.9$ mV, $x = 0$ positive; (d) no.)

Problem 1.8 A spreading packet of carriers

C · Synthesis

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 6.28, p. 237

A short pulse of light creates, at $t = 0$, a thin sheet of N_s holes per cm² at $x = 0$ in a silicon bar. Ignore recombination (the time scale is short) and, at first, any field.

(a) Combine the continuity equation without generation or recombination and the diffusion flux to obtain the diffusion equation $\partial p/\partial t = D_p\,\partial^2 p/\partial x^2$.

(b) Show that $p(x,t) = \dfrac{N_s}{\sqrt{4\pi D_p t}}\exp\!\left(-\dfrac{x^2}{4D_p t}\right)$ is a solution, and that $\int_{-\infty}^{+\infty} p\,\mathrm{d}x = N_s$ at all times. What does the second result express?

(c) The width of the packet is measured by its standard deviation $\sqrt{2D_p t}$. Compute it after 1 µs.

(d) A field of 10 V/cm is now applied along $+x$. Where is the centre of the packet after 1 µs? Compare the drift distance with the width. Show that their ratio is $\dfrac{\mathcal{E}}{kT/q}\sqrt{\dfrac{D_p t}{2}}$, and explain why measuring the arrival time and the width of the packet at a second contact gives both μ_p and D_p (the principle of the Haynes–Shockley experiment, Neamen, Problem 6.27, p. 237).

> **HINT**
> In (b), write $p = At^{-1/2}\mathrm{e}^{-x^2/4D_p t}$ and differentiate. For the integral, use $\int_{-\infty}^{+\infty}\mathrm{e}^{-ax^2}\mathrm{d}x = \sqrt{\pi/a}$.

(Answer: (c) 49 µm; (d) 46 µm along $+x$, comparable to the width.)

Challenge: a new situation
These problems apply the method of the chapter to a device, a material or a situation that the chapter did not treat. The reasoning does not change: state the physical picture, choose the model, compute, check.

Problem 1.9 Drift and diffusion in gallium arsenide

C · Synthesis

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 5.37, p. 189

A uniform field $\mathcal{E} = 12$ V/cm along $+x$ exists in n-type GaAs between $x = 0$ and $x = 50$ µm, at 300 K. The total electron current density is constant, $J_n = 100$ A/cm², and at $x = 0$ the drift and diffusion currents are equal. Take $\mu_n = 8000$ cm²/(V·s).

(a) Find D_n, and write the equation $J_n = q\mu_n n\mathcal{E} + qD_n\,\mathrm{d}n/\mathrm{d}x$ as a first-order differential equation for $n(x)$.

(b) Solve it with the condition at $x = 0$. What length characterises the variation of n, and what is its physical meaning?

(c) Compute $n(0)$ and $n(50\ \mu\mathrm{m})$, and the drift and diffusion currents at $x = 50$ µm.

HINT
The equation has a constant particular solution, for which the whole current is drift.

(Answer: (a) $D_n = 207$ cm²/s; (b) $n(x) = n_\infty(1 - \frac{1}{2}\mathrm{e}^{-x/\ell})$ with $n_\infty = 6.50 \times 10^{15}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$ and $\ell = kT/(q\mathcal{E}) = 21.6$ µm; (c) 3.25×10^{15} and $6.18 \times 10^{15}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$; 95.1 and 4.9 A/cm².)

SEMICONDUCTOR DEVICES PHYSICS · EXERCISES

CHAPTER 2

Pure and Doped Semiconductors at Equilibrium: A Qualitative View

WHAT THIS SET USES

Bonds, electron–hole pairs and holes; generation and recombination, $R = \alpha\, np$ and $G_i = \alpha n_i^2$; equilibrium and the mass-action law $n_0 p_0 = n_i^2$; donors and acceptors; the three laws for the doped sample: neutrality $n_0 + N_A = p_0 + N_D$, mass action, complete ionisation; majority and minority carriers; the conductivity $\sigma = q(n\mu_n + p\mu_p)$ of Chapter 1. The Fermi level is not used in this set.

DATA

Silicon at 300 K: $n_i = 10^{10}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $\mu_n = 1350$, $\mu_p = 460$ cm²/(V·s) unless a problem gives other values. Germanium: $n_i = 2.4 \times 10^{13}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; GaAs: $n_i = 1.8 \times 10^{6}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$.

Problem 2.1 Which atom gives which carrier? A · Understanding

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 1, Problem 6, p. 41

A dopant is a donor or an acceptor according to the number of valence electrons it brings compared with the atom it replaces.

(a) Silicon (column IV) is doped with phosphorus (column V), then with boron (column III). Draw the bonds around each impurity at 0 K and say which one is a donor.

(b) Gallium arsenide is a compound of gallium (column III) and arsenic (column V). Tin (column IV) is added and replaces gallium atoms. Is tin a donor or an acceptor? Is the material n- or p-type?

(c) Silicon atoms can also be added to GaAs. Explain why a silicon atom on a gallium site is a donor, and a silicon atom on an arsenic site an acceptor. (Problem 2.8 uses this.)

HINT

Count the electrons available for the four bonds of the site, and compare with the eight shared electrons of a complete set of bonds.

(Answer: (a) P donor, B acceptor; (b) donor, n-type; (c) one electron in excess on a Ga site, one missing on an As site.)

Problem 2.2 Compensated samples B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problems 4.34 and 4.39, pp. 151–152

Silicon at 300 K, complete ionisation.

(a) Write the three laws for a sample containing N_D donors and N_A acceptors, and show that, when $N_D > N_A$, $n_0 = \frac{N_D - N_A}{2} + \sqrt{\left(\frac{N_D - N_A}{2}\right)^2 + n_i^2}$.

(b) Find n_0 and p_0 for: (i) $N_D = 10^{15}$, $N_A = 4\times10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; (ii) $N_D = 3\times10^{16}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $N_A = 0$; (iii) $N_D = N_A = 2\times10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$. Say in each case whether the sample is n-type, p-type or behaves as pure silicon.

(c) A sample contains 2×10^{15} arsenic atoms and 1.2×10^{15} boron atoms per cm³. Find n_0 and p_0.

(d) Boron is added to the sample of (c) until $p_0 = 4\times10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$. How many boron atoms per cm³ must be added? What is the new n_0?

> **HINT**
> When $|N_D - N_A| \gg n_i$ the square root reduces to $|N_D - N_A|/2$: the majority density is the net doping, and the minority density follows from mass action.

(Answer: (b) (i) p-type, $p_0 = 3\times10^{15}$, $n_0 = 3.3\times10^{4}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; (ii) n-type, $n_0 = 3\times10^{16}$, $p_0 = 3.3\times10^{3}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; (iii) $n_0 = p_0 = 10^{10}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; (c) $n_0 = 8\times10^{14}$, $p_0 = 1.25\times10^{5}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; (d) $4.8\times10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $n_0 = 2.5\times10^{4}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$.)

Problem 2.3 When n_i is not negligible — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 1, Problem 18, p. 42, and Neamen, Problem 4.45, p. 152

(a) A germanium sample is doped with $N_D = 2.5\times10^{13}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$ donors, fully ionised, at 300 K, where n_i of germanium is taken as $2.5\times10^{13}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$. Why can the majority-carrier approximation $n_0 \simeq N_D$ not be used? Compute n_0 and p_0, and the error that the approximation would make on n_0.

(b) In another material, doped with $N_D = 2\times10^{14}$ and $N_A = 1.2\times10^{14}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, the electron density is measured: $n_0 = 1.1\times10^{14}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$. Using the neutrality and mass-action laws, find n_i and p_0.

(c) In (b), check your result by verifying neutrality with the computed values.

> **HINT**
> In (b) eliminate p_0 between the two laws: $n_i^2 = n_0^2 - n_0(N_D - N_A)$.

(Answer: (a) $n_0 = 4.05\times10^{13}$, $p_0 = 1.55\times10^{13}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; the approximation underestimates n_0 by 38 %; (b) $n_i = 5.7\times10^{13}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $p_0 = 3.0\times10^{13}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$.)

Problem 2.4 Designing a resistor — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 5.51, p. 190

A silicon resistor must carry 5 mA under 5 V. Its cross-section is a square of 100 µm × 100 µm.

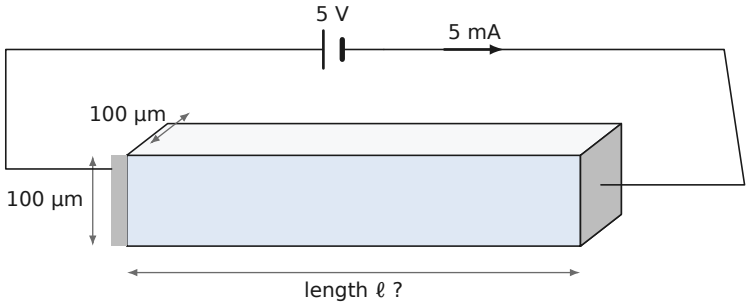
(a) What resistance is required?

(b) The silicon is n-type with $N_D = 3\times10^{14}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$ and $N_A = 0$ ($\mu_n = 1350$ cm²/(V·s)). Compute the conductivity, neglecting the holes, and the length of the resistor. Check that neglecting the holes is justified.

(c) The resistor is now made of compensated silicon, $N_D = 3\times10^{16}$ and $N_A = 2.5\times10^{16}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, in which the electron mobility, lowered by the many ionised impurities, is

measured as 1000 cm²/(V·s). Compute n_0, the conductivity and the new length.

(d) The electron density is multiplied by 16.7 between (b) and (c). Is the length multiplied by the same factor? Explain.



The bar resistor (not to scale).

> **HINT**
> $R = L/(\sigma A)$, so $L = R\sigma A$.

(Answer: (a) 1 kΩ; (b) $\sigma = 0.0649$ S/cm, $L = 64.9$ µm; (c) $n_0 = 5\times10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $\sigma = 0.801$ S/cm, $L = 801$ µm; (d) no, 12.3, because of the lower mobility.)

Problem 2.5 Is pure silicon the most resistive? B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 5.22, p. 187

The conductivity of silicon at 300 K is $\sigma = q(n_0\mu_n + p_0\mu_p)$, with $n_0 p_0 = n_i^2$. Consider it as a function of p_0.

(a) Show that σ is smallest for $p_0 = n_i\sqrt{\mu_n/\mu_p}$, and that the minimum is $\sigma_{min} = 2qn_i\sqrt{\mu_n\mu_p}$.

(b) Show that $\sigma_{min}/\sigma_i = 2\sqrt{\mu_n\mu_p}/(\mu_n+\mu_p)$, where σ_i is the conductivity of pure silicon, and evaluate the ratio. Compute ρ_i and ρ_{max}.

(c) Is the material at the minimum n- or p-type? What net doping $N_A - N_D$ gives it?

(d) Why does a small number of acceptors *increase* the resistivity of pure silicon?

> **HINT**
> Write $\sigma(p_0) = q(\mu_n n_i^2/p_0 + \mu_p p_0)$ and set $\mathrm{d}\sigma/\mathrm{d}p_0 = 0$.

(Answer: (a) $p_0 = 1.71\times10^{10}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; (b) 0.871; $\rho_i = 3.45\times10^5$ Ω·cm, $\rho_{max} = 3.96\times10^5$ Ω·cm; (c) p-type, $N_A - N_D = 1.13\times10^{10}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$.)

Problem 2.6 Halving a resistance by counter-doping B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 2, Problem 9, p. 79

A silicon bar doped with $N_D \gg n_i$ donors has a resistance R_1. Acceptors are then added to the same bar, $N_A > N_D$, and its resistance becomes $R_1/2$. Take the mobilities constant, $\mu_n/\mu_p = 1350/460$.

(a) Write the conductivity before and after the addition of the acceptors.

(b) Deduce N_A in terms of N_D.

(c) Why must N_A be several times larger than N_D to halve the resistance, and not simply about $2N_D$?

> **HINT**
> After the addition the majority carriers are holes, and their density is the net doping $N_A - N_D$.

(Answer: (b) $N_A = (1 + 2\mu_n/\mu_p)N_D = 6.9\,N_D$.)

Problem 2.7 The generic recombination model in numbers B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problems 6.1 and 6.3, p. 233

In the generic model of the chapter, the recombination rate is $R = \alpha\, np$ and thermal generation is $G_i = \alpha n_i^2$. In an n-type sample, an individual hole disappears at the rate αn_0, so its mean lifetime is $\tau_p = 1/(\alpha n_0)$.

(a) A silicon sample has $N_D = 10^{16}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$ and a measured hole lifetime $\tau_p = 20$ µs. Find α, the thermal generation rate G_i and the equilibrium recombination rate R_0.

(b) What is the mean time that an electron of this sample waits before recombining? Comment on the difference between the two lifetimes.

(c) Another sample has $N_D = 5 \times 10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$ and $\tau_p = 0.2$ µs. Find α and R_0. Why is R_0 the same as G_i in each sample, whatever τ_p?

> **HINT**
> At equilibrium $R_0 = \alpha n_0 p_0 = \alpha n_i^2$.

(Answer: (a) $\alpha = 5 \times 10^{-12}$ cm³/s, $G_i = R_0 = 5 \times 10^{8}$ cm^{-3}s^{-1}; (b) 2×10^{7} s; (c) $\alpha = 10^{-9}$ cm³/s, $R_0 = 10^{11}$ cm^{-3}s^{-1}.)

> **Challenge: a new situation**
> These problems apply the method of the chapter to a device, a material or a situation that the chapter did not treat. The reasoning does not change: state the physical picture, choose the model, compute, check.

Problem 2.8 An impurity that is both donor and acceptor

C · Synthesis

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 4.62, p. 154

Silicon is added to gallium arsenide at a concentration of $7 \times 10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$. Five percent of the silicon atoms replace gallium atoms and 95 percent replace arsenic atoms (Problem 2.1). All are ionised. GaAs at 300 K: $n_i = 1.8 \times 10^{6}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$.

(a) Find N_D and N_A. Is the material n- or p-type?

(b) Find p_0 and n_0.

(c) The value of n_0 is far below one electron per cm³. What does such a density mean physically, and is the mass-action law still meaningful?

(d) Compare with silicon doped with the same net doping. Why is the minority density so much smaller in GaAs?

> **HINT**
>
> A density is an average over volume and time.

(Answer: (a) $N_D = 3.5 \times 10^{14}$, $N_A = 6.65 \times 10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, p-type; (b) $p_0 = 6.3 \times 10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $n_0 = 5.1 \times 10^{-4}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; (d) silicon: $n_0 = 1.6 \times 10^{4}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$.)

SEMICONDUCTOR DEVICES PHYSICS · EXERCISES

CHAPTER 3

Pure and Doped Semiconductors at Equilibrium: Energy Bands and the Fermi Level

WHAT THIS SET USES

Bands and gap; the Fermi–Dirac function and its Boltzmann limit; effective mass and density of states $g_C(E) \propto \sqrt{E-E_C}$; $n_0 = N_C\,\mathrm{e}^{-(E_C-E_F)/kT}$, $p_0 = N_V\,\mathrm{e}^{-(E_F-E_V)/kT}$ with $N_{C,V} = 2(2\pi m^* kT/h^2)^{3/2}$; $n_i = \sqrt{N_C N_V}\,\mathrm{e}^{-E_g/2kT}$ and the intrinsic level E_i; $n_0 = n_i\,\mathrm{e}^{(E_F-E_i)/kT}$; ionised donors $N_D^+ = N_D/[1+2\,\mathrm{e}^{(E_F-E_D)/kT}]$; the position of E_F in doped material.

DATA

Silicon: $E_g = 1.12$ eV (held constant with T), $N_C = 2.8\times10^{19}$, $N_V = 1.04\times10^{19}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$ at 300 K, both $\propto T^{3/2}$; $n_i = 10^{10}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$ at 300 K and $n_i(T) = 10^{10}(T/300)^{3/2}\exp[-\frac{E_g}{2k}(\frac{1}{T}-\frac{1}{300})]\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$; $k = 8.617\times10^{-5}$ eV/K; donor and acceptor levels 45 meV from their band edge.

Problem 3.1 Where are the conduction electrons? B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problems 4.6 and 4.7, p. 150

In the Boltzmann limit, the number of electrons per unit energy in the conduction band is $n(E) = g_C(E)f(E) \propto \sqrt{E-E_C}\,\mathrm{e}^{-(E-E_F)/kT}$.

(a) Sketch $\sqrt{E-E_C}$, $\mathrm{e}^{-(E-E_F)/kT}$ and their product above E_C. Explain why the product vanishes at E_C and at high energy.

(b) Show that $n(E)$ is largest at $E = E_C + kT/2$. Give this energy at 300 K.

(c) Compute the ratio $n(E_C+4kT)/n(E_C+kT/2)$. What does it say about the energies of the conduction electrons?

(d) Without calculation, where is the maximum of the hole distribution $g_V(E)[1-f(E)]$?

HINT

Set $u = (E-E_C)/kT$ and maximise $\sqrt{u}\,\mathrm{e}^{-u}$.

(Answer: (b) 13 meV above E_C; (c) 0.085; (d) $kT/2$ below E_V.)

Problem 3.2 Effective masses from the densities of states B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 1, Problem 9, p. 41

The effective density of states is $N_V = 2\left(\dfrac{2\pi m_p^* kT}{h^2}\right)^{3/2}$, and similarly for N_C with m_n^*.

(a) Explain why N_V can be read as 'the number of states per cm³ that would be needed at the single energy E_V to hold all the holes'.

(b) From $N_V = 1.04 \times 10^{19}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$ and $N_C = 2.8 \times 10^{19}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$ at 300 K, compute m_p^* and m_n^* for silicon in units of m_0.

(c) From $N_V = 7.0 \times 10^{18}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$ for GaAs, compute m_p^*. The table of the course gives $m_p^* = 0.48\,m_0$ for GaAs: what value of N_V does this mass give? Comment.

> **HINT**
>
> Work in SI units: N in m^{-3}, then $m^* = \dfrac{h^2}{2\pi kT}\left(\dfrac{N}{2}\right)^{2/3}$.

(Answer: (b) $m_p^* = 0.56\,m_0$, $m_n^* = 1.08\,m_0$; (c) $0.43\,m_0$; $0.48\,m_0$ gives $N_V = 8.4 \times 10^{18}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$.)

Problem 3.3 Placing the Fermi level B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problems 4.17, 4.24 and 4.25, pp. 150–151

(a) Silicon at 300 K is doped with arsenic so that $n_0 = 7 \times 10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$. Find $E_C - E_F$, $E_F - E_V$, p_0 and $E_F - E_i$. Which carrier is the minority carrier?

(b) Silicon at 300 K is doped with boron so that $p_0 = 5 \times 10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$. Find $E_F - E_V$, $E_C - E_F$, n_0 and $E_i - E_F$.

(c) The sample of (b) is heated to 400 K; p_0 stays $5 \times 10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$. Compute N_V and n_i at 400 K, then $E_F - E_V$, n_0 and $E_i - E_F$. Does the Fermi level move towards or away from E_i? Why?

> **HINT**
>
> Use $E_C - E_F = kT\ln(N_C/n_0)$ and $E_F - E_i = kT\ln(n_0/n_i)$, and the same forms for holes; $kT = 34.5$ meV at 400 K.

(Answer: (a) 0.215, 0.905 eV, $p_0 = 1.43 \times 10^4\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $E_F - E_i = 0.349$ eV; (b) 0.198, 0.922 eV, $n_0 = 2 \times 10^4\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, 0.340 eV; (c) $N_V = 1.60 \times 10^{19}$, $n_i = 3.5 \times 10^{12}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, 0.278 eV, $n_0 = 2.4 \times 10^9\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, 0.251 eV: towards E_i.)

Problem 3.4 Doping for a given Fermi level B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 1, Problem 14, p. 42

A silicon sample at 300 K contains $N_A = 10^{16}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$ acceptors. Donors are added so that the material becomes n-type with E_F 0.20 eV below E_C.

(a) What electron density does this position of E_F correspond to?

(b) Using neutrality with complete ionisation, find the required N_D.

(c) Check that the donors are indeed fully ionised at this Fermi level ($E_C - E_D = 45$ meV).

> **HINT**
> The added donors must first compensate the acceptors.

(Answer: (a) $n_0 = 1.24 \times 10^{16}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; (b) $N_D = 2.24 \times 10^{16}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; (c) $N_D^+/N_D = 0.995$.)

Problem 3.5 A small difference of gap, a large difference of n_i — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 4.5, p. 150

Two semiconductors A and B have identical properties except their gaps: 0.90 eV for A and 1.10 eV for B.

(a) Show that $n_{iB}/n_{iA} = \exp[-(E_{gB} - E_{gA})/2kT]$.

(b) Evaluate the ratio at 200, 300 and 400 K.

(c) Explain physically why the ratio approaches 1 when the temperature rises.

(Answer: (b) 3.0×10^{-3}, 2.1×10^{-2}, 5.5×10^{-2}.)

Problem 3.6 How hot can a device run? — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problems 4.3 and 4.50, pp. 149 and 153

Use the expression of $n_i(T)$ given in the data, with E_g constant.

(a) A silicon device works properly only if $n_i \le 5 \times 10^{11}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$. Find the maximum temperature, by trial. Repeat for $5 \times 10^{12}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$.

(b) A device is doped with $N_D = 10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$. It requires that thermal pairs contribute no more than 5 % of the electron density, i.e. $n_0 \le 1.05\,N_D$. Show that this means $p_0 \le 0.05\,N_D$, and deduce the maximum value of n_i, then the maximum temperature.

(c) At that temperature, compute $E_C - E_F$ and $E_F - E_i$, and compare with 300 K. Is the Fermi level closer to or further from the intrinsic level?

> **HINT**
> In (b), neutrality gives $n_0 - p_0 = N_D$, so $n_0 = 1.05 N_D$ means $p_0 = 0.05 N_D$, and $n_i^2 = n_0 p_0$.

(Answer: (a) 361 K and 408 K; (b) $n_i \le 2.3 \times 10^{14}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $T_{max} \approx 522$ K; (c) $E_C - E_F$: 0.265 eV at 300 K, 0.496 eV at 522 K; $E_F - E_i$: 0.298 and 0.068 eV, closer.)

Problem 3.7 Is complete ionisation justified? — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 1, Problem 20, p. 42

Silicon at 300 K is doped with phosphorus ($E_C - E_D = 45$ meV) at $N_D = 10^{15}$, 10^{17} and $10^{19}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$.

(a) Assuming complete ionisation, compute $E_C - E_F$ for each doping.

(b) With this E_F, compute $N_D^+/N_D = 1/[1 + 2\,\text{e}^{(E_F - E_D)/kT}]$. For which dopings is the assumption justified?

(c) For the highest doping, what goes wrong besides incomplete ionisation? Which assumption of the formula $n_0 = N_C\,\mathrm{e}^{-(E_C-E_F)/kT}$ fails?

(Answer: (a) 0.265, 0.146, 0.027 eV; (b) 0.9996, 0.96, 0.20: justified for 10^{15}, acceptable for 10^{17}, not for 10^{19}; (c) E_F is within kT of E_C: the Boltzmann approximation fails.)

Challenge: a new situation
These problems apply the method of the chapter to a device, a material or a situation that the chapter did not treat. The reasoning does not change: state the physical picture, choose the model, compute, check.

Problem 3.8 The limit of the Boltzmann approximation

C · Synthesis

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 4.32, p. 151

For the Boltzmann expression of the occupation of the donor levels to hold, the Fermi level must be at least $3kT$ below the donor level in n-type material, and at least $3kT$ above the acceptor level in p-type material.

(a) In silicon at 300 K with $E_C - E_D = 45$ meV, what is the highest electron density allowed? With $E_A - E_V = 45$ meV, the highest hole density?

(b) At this limit, what fraction of the donors is ionised? Is complete ionisation a good assumption there?

(c) Compare with Problem 3.7. Why is the limit on holes lower than the limit on electrons?

(Answer: (a) $n_{max} = 2.5\times10^{17}$, $p_{max} = 9.1\times10^{16}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$; (b) 91 %.)

Problem 3.9 A new semiconductor

C · Synthesis

Adapted from Neamen, Problems 4.53 and 4.61, pp. 153–154

(a) A semiconductor has $E_g = 1.50$ eV, $m_p^* = 10\,m_n^*$ and $n_i = 10^5\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$ at 300 K. Where is E_i with respect to midgap? Impurities are added so that E_F is 0.45 eV below midgap: donors or acceptors? What net concentration?

(b) A new p-type material is to be designed, doped with $N_A = 5\times10^{15}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$ ($N_D = 0$). At 300 K, $N_C = 1.2\times10^{19}$ and $N_V = 1.8\times10^{19}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$, both proportional to $T^{3/2}$. A device made of it requires $p_0 \le 5.08\times10^{15}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$ at 350 K. What is the smallest gap that meets the requirement?

HINT
(a) $E_i - E_{mid} = \frac{3}{4}kT\ln(m_p^*/m_n^*)$. (b) Neutrality gives $p_0(p_0 - N_A) = n_i^2$: find the largest allowed n_i, then the gap.

(Answer: (a) E_i is 44.7 meV above midgap; acceptors, $2\times10^{13}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$; (b) $E_g \ge 0.62$ eV.)

SEMICONDUCTOR DEVICES PHYSICS · EXERCISES

CHAPTER 4

Carriers Out of Equilibrium

WHAT THIS SET USES

Equilibrium, steady state and transient; the excess densities Δn, Δp and the lifetime τ; the return to equilibrium $e^{-t/\tau}$; absorption above E_g and the generation rate g_0; Case A (uniform light), $\Delta n = \tau g_0$ and $\Delta\sigma = q(\mu_n + \mu_p)\Delta n$; the continuity equations with generation and recombination; the diffusion length $L = \sqrt{D\tau}$; Case B (illuminated surface) and the internal field; the ambipolar coefficient $D_a = (n+p)/(n/D_p + p/D_n)$.

DATA

Silicon at 300 K: $n_i = 10^{10}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $\mu_n = 1350$, $\mu_p = 460$ cm²/(V·s), $D_n = 35$, $D_p = 12$ cm²/s unless the problem gives other values; $hc = 1240$ eV·nm. Low-level injection unless stated otherwise.

Problem 4.1 The balance of a slice

A · Understanding

Adapted from Neamen, Problems 6.6 and 6.7, p. 234

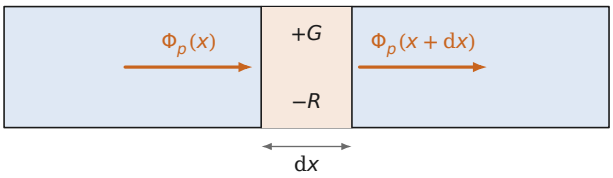
In one dimension the continuity equation for holes reads $\dfrac{\partial p}{\partial t} = -\dfrac{\partial \Phi_p}{\partial x} + G - R$, where Φ_p is the hole flux.

(a) Say in words what each term counts, for a thin slice of the sample.

(b) In a slice, holes are generated at $G = 10^{20}$ and recombine at $R = 2\times10^{19}$ cm^{-3}s^{-1}. What must $\partial\Phi_p/\partial x$ be for the hole density to stay constant? Do more holes leave or enter the slice?

(c) Repeat if the light is switched off ($G = 0$) while R keeps its value.

(d) Classify the following as equilibrium, steady state or transient: (i) a sample in the dark at constant temperature; (ii) a sample under constant light for a long time; (iii) the first microseconds after the light is switched on; (iv) a diode carrying a constant current.



A thin slice of the sample: what enters, what leaves, what is created and what disappears.

(Answer: (b) $+8\times10^{19}$ cm^{-3}s^{-1}, more holes leave; (c) -2×10^{19} cm^{-3}s^{-1}, more enter; (d) equilibrium; steady state; transient; steady state.)

Problem 4.2 From watts of light to excess carriers

B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 6.4, p. 234

A silicon sample of 1 cm² cross-section and 0.1 cm thickness absorbs uniformly 1 W of red light at 630 nm. Each absorbed photon creates one electron–hole pair.

(a) Compute the photon energy and the number of photons absorbed per second.

(b) Deduce the generation rate g_0 per cm³ and per second.

(c) The lifetime of the excess carriers is 10 µs. What is the steady excess density (Case A)? Is low-level injection satisfied for a doping of $10^{16}\,\mathrm{cm^{-3}}$?

(d) What fraction of the light power is turned into heat at once, before any recombination? Explain where this energy goes.

> **HINT**
> $E = hc/\lambda$; the number of photons per second is the power divided by the energy of one photon.

(Answer: (a) 1.97 eV, 3.2×10^{18} s^{-1}; (b) 3.2×10^{19} cm^{-3}s^{-1}; (c) $3.2\times10^{14}\,\mathrm{cm^{-3}}$, yes; (d) 43 %.)

Problem 4.3 Light on, light off

B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problems 6.15 and 6.17, p. 235

An n-type silicon sample ($N_D = 10^{16}\,\mathrm{cm^{-3}}$) has a hole lifetime $\tau_p = 0.5$ µs. At $t = 0$ a light is switched on that generates $g_0 = 5\times10^{20}$ cm^{-3}s^{-1} uniformly.

(a) Write the equation for $\Delta p(t)$ while the light is on, and solve it. What is the steady value?

(b) Find the times at which Δp reaches one quarter, one half, three quarters and 95 % of its steady value.

(c) The light is switched off at $t_1 = 0.5$ µs. Give $\Delta p(t_1)$ and $\Delta p(t)$ for $t > t_1$. Sketch $\Delta p(t)$.

(d) Repeat (c) for $t_1 = 2$ µs. Why does the excess at the switch-off barely differ from the steady value?

> **HINT**
> $\mathrm{d}\Delta p/\mathrm{d}t = g_0 - \Delta p/\tau_p$.

(Answer: (a) $\Delta p = \tau_p g_0(1 - \mathrm{e}^{-t/\tau_p})$, $2.5\times10^{14}\,\mathrm{cm^{-3}}$; (b) 0.14, 0.35, 0.69 and 1.50 µs; (c) $1.58\times10^{14}\,\mathrm{cm^{-3}}$; (d) $2.45\times10^{14}\,\mathrm{cm^{-3}}$.)

Problem 4.4 A photoconductor switched off

B · Guided calculation

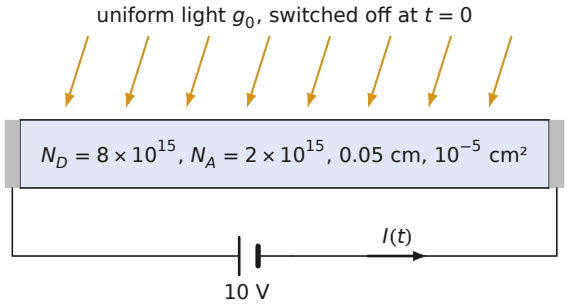
Adapted from Neamen, Problem 6.14, p. 234

A silicon bar is 0.05 cm long, with cross-section 10^{-5} cm², doped with $N_D = 8\times10^{15}$ and $N_A = 2\times10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$. A voltage of 10 V is applied along it. For $t < 0$ the bar has been illuminated for a long time, with a uniform generation rate $g_0 = 8\times10^{20}\ \text{cm}^{-3}\text{s}^{-1}$; the light is switched off at $t = 0$. The minority lifetime is $\tau_p = 0.5$ µs. Because of the compensating impurities, take $\mu_n = 1200$ and $\mu_p = 420$ cm²/(V·s).

(a) Find n_0, p_0 and the excess density before $t = 0$.

(b) Write the current $I(t)$ for $t \geq 0$ as a dark current plus a photocurrent, and evaluate both.

(c) By what fraction does the light raise the current? After how long is the photocurrent below 1 % of its initial value?



The photoconductor.

> **HINT**
> $I = \sigma\mathcal{E}A$ with $\sigma = q(n\mu_n + p\mu_p)$, $n = n_0 + \Delta n$, $p = p_0 + \Delta p$, $\Delta n = \Delta p$.

(Answer: (a) $n_0 = 6\times10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $p_0 \approx 1.7\times10^{4}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $\Delta p = 4\times10^{14}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; (b) $I = 2.31 + 0.21\,\text{e}^{-t/\tau_p}$ mA; (c) 9 %, after 2.3 µs.)

Problem 4.5 Light at the end of a bar

B · Guided calculation

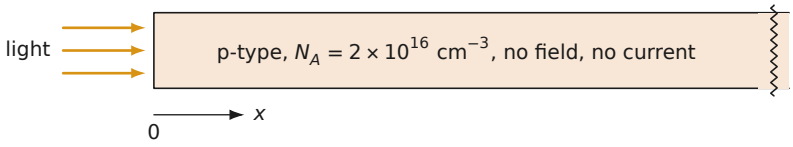
Adapted from Neamen, Problem 6.19, p. 235

A long p-type silicon bar ($N_A = 2\times10^{16}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$) is illuminated at its end $x = 0$ only, so that in steady state $\Delta n(0) = \Delta p(0) = 2\times10^{14}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$. No external field is applied and no current flows through the bar. The electron lifetime is $\tau_n = 1$ µs.

(a) Write the steady-state equation for the minority excess in the dark part, $x > 0$, and solve it. Compute L_n.

(b) Compute the electron and hole diffusion current densities at $x = 0$ and give their directions.

(c) The bar is open-circuited. Show that the total current would not be zero with diffusion alone, and find the small field that restores $J = 0$ at $x = 0$. Which carriers carry the drift current, and why is the field small?



Light absorbed at the end of a long bar. After Neamen, Fig. P6.19, p. 235.

HINT

In low injection the profile is set by the minority carriers; the majority excess follows it so that the sample stays neutral, $\Delta p \simeq \Delta n$.

(Answer: (a) $\Delta n = 2 \times 10^{14}\, e^{-x/L_n}$, $L_n = 59$ µm; (b) $J_n = -0.190$ A/cm², $J_p = +0.065$ A/cm²; (c) $\mathcal{E}(0) = 0.085$ V/cm.)

Problem 4.6 Injected at one face, collected at the other

C · Synthesis

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 2, Problems 17 and 18, p. 80

Excess holes are injected at the face $x = 0$ of a thin n-type slab of thickness W and extracted at the opposite face, which holds them at equilibrium: $\Delta p(0) = \Delta p_0$, $\Delta p(W) = 0$. There is no field in the slab.

(a) Solve the steady-state equation $D_p\, \mathrm{d}^2\Delta p/\mathrm{d}x^2 = \Delta p/\tau_p$ with these conditions. Show that $\Delta p(x) = \Delta p_0 \dfrac{\sinh[(W-x)/L_p]}{\sinh(W/L_p)}$.

(b) Compute the hole current densities at $x = 0$ and at $x = W$, and show that the fraction of the injected current that reaches the far face is $1/\cosh(W/L_p)$.

(c) Evaluate this fraction for $\tau_p = 50$ µs, $D_p = 50$ cm²/s and $W = 0.1$ mm. Then for $W = L_p$ and $W = 3L_p$.

(d) Show that for $W \ll L_p$ the profile tends to a straight line and the fraction to $1 - W^2/2L_p^2$. Where does this result reappear in the course?

HINT

The general solution is $A\sinh(x/L_p) + B\cosh(x/L_p)$; it is convenient to write it as a combination of $\sinh[(W-x)/L_p]$ and $\sinh(x/L_p)$.

(Answer: (b) $J(0) = qD_p\Delta p_0 \coth(W/L_p)/L_p$, $J(W) = qD_p\Delta p_0/[L_p \sinh(W/L_p)]$; (c) $L_p = 500$ µm, 0.980; 0.648; 0.099.)

Challenge: a new situation

These problems apply the method of the chapter to a device, a material or a situation that the chapter did not treat. The reasoning does not change: state the physical picture, choose the model, compute, check.

Problem 4.7 Ambipolar diffusion in germanium

C · Synthesis

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 6.10, p. 234

Germanium at 300 K ($n_i = 2.4 \times 10^{13}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $\mu_n = 3900$, $\mu_p = 1900$ cm²/(V·s)) is doped with $N_D = 4 \times 10^{13}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$ donors. The excess-carrier lifetime is 2 µs.

(a) Compute n_0 and p_0, without the majority-carrier approximation. Why is it not valid here?

(b) Compute D_n, D_p and the ambipolar coefficient D_a in low injection. Compare D_a with D_p, which it would equal in strongly n-type material.

(c) Compute the diffusion length of the excess carriers.

(d) Explain physically why the excess electrons and holes diffuse together with a coefficient that lies between D_n and D_p.

> **HINT**
> $n_0 = \frac{N_D}{2} + \sqrt{\frac{N_D^2}{4} + n_i^2}$ (Chapter 2).

(Answer: (a) $n_0 = 5.12 \times 10^{13}$, $p_0 = 1.12 \times 10^{13}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; (b) $D_n = 101$, $D_p = 49.2$, $D_a = 54.2$ cm²/s; (c) $L = 104$ µm.)

Problem 4.8 Minority carriers in an applied field

C · Synthesis

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 6.22, p. 236

In n-type silicon, holes are generated in a thin plane at $x = 0$ and spread on both sides. A uniform field $\mathcal{E}_0$ is applied along $+x$. The hole lifetime is $\tau_p = 10$ µs.

(a) Write the steady-state continuity equation for Δp with diffusion, drift and recombination, and show that it has solutions e^{sx} with $s = \frac{1}{L_p}\left(\beta \pm \sqrt{1+\beta^2}\right)$, $\beta = \frac{\mu_p \mathcal{E}_0 L_p}{2 D_p}$.

(b) Choose the root that keeps Δp finite on each side, and give the decay lengths downstream ($x > 0$) and upstream ($x < 0$).

(c) Evaluate them for $\mathcal{E}_0 = 0$ and for $\mathcal{E}_0 = 10$ V/cm. Sketch the profiles.

(d) Explain the result in terms of the distance drifted in one lifetime.

> **HINT**
> The hole flux is $\mu_p \mathcal{E}_0 p - D_p\,\mathrm{d}p/\mathrm{d}x$; in the n-type material the field does not change p_0.

(Answer: (c) $L_p = 110$ µm both ways for $\mathcal{E}_0 = 0$; for 10 V/cm, $\beta = 2.10$: 485 µm downstream, 25 µm upstream.)

SEMICONDUCTOR DEVICES PHYSICS · EXERCISES

CHAPTER 5

The PN Junction at Equilibrium

WHAT THIS SET USES

The constant Fermi level; the depletion layer and the depletion approximation; Poisson's equation, the triangular field and the parabolic potential; $V_d = \frac{kT}{q}\ln\frac{N_A N_D}{n_i^2}$; $W = \sqrt{\frac{2\varepsilon V_d}{q}\frac{N_A+N_D}{N_A N_D}}$, $N_A W_p = N_D W_n$, $\mathcal{E}_{max} = qN_D W_n/\varepsilon$; the band diagram and the carrier densities across the junction; N side grounded.

DATA

Silicon at 300 K: $n_i = 10^{10}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $kT/q = 25.9$ mV, $\varepsilon = 1.036\times10^{-12}$ F/cm, $N_C = 2.8\times10^{19}$, $N_V = 1.04\times10^{19}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $E_g = 1.12$ eV. Abrupt junctions with uniform doping on each side unless stated otherwise.

Problem 5.1 Reading a band diagram

B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 7.6, p. 269

A silicon junction at equilibrium is doped so that, in the neutral regions, $E_F - E_i = 0.365$ eV on the N side and $E_i - E_F = 0.330$ eV on the P side.

(a) Sketch the band diagram of the two pieces apart, then of the junction, with E_F flat. Mark qV_d.

(b) Deduce N_D and N_A.

(c) Read V_d on the diagram, and check it with the formula for V_d.

HINT

On the diagram, qV_d is the step of E_i between the two neutral regions, which is the distance between the two Fermi levels of the pieces apart.

(Answer: (b) $N_D = 1.32\times10^{16}$, $N_A = 3.42\times10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; (c) $V_d = 0.695$ V.)

Problem 5.2 From the SCR back to the dopings

B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 7.8, p. 270

A silicon junction at equilibrium has $V_d = 0.710$ V, and 25 % of its SCR lies in the N region.

(a) Using the neutrality of the SCR, find the ratio N_A/N_D. Which side is more heavily doped?

(b) Find N_A and N_D.

(c) Compute W, W_n, W_p and $\mathcal{E}_{max}$.

(d) Sketch the charge density and the field. Where is the field largest?

> **HINT**
> $N_A W_p = N_D W_n$: the SCR extends further into the less doped side.

(Answer: (a) $N_A/N_D = 1/3$; (b) $N_A = 5.2\times10^{15}$, $N_D = 1.55\times10^{16}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; (c) $W = 0.486$ µm, $W_n = 0.122$ µm, $W_p = 0.365$ µm, $\mathcal{E}_{max} = 2.9\times10^{4}$ V/cm.)

Problem 5.3 A junction with an almost pure side — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 7.13, p. 270

An n region with $N_D = 10^{16}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$ meets a very lightly doped p region with $N_A = 10^{12}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, a model for an n region next to nearly intrinsic silicon.

(a) Compute V_d. Why is it much smaller than that of the reference junction (0.835 V)?

(b) Compute W_n, W_p and $\mathcal{E}_{max}$. Sketch the field.

(c) Compare W_p with the reference junction. What would happen to the SCR if the p region were only 10 µm thick?

(Answer: (a) 0.477 V; (b) $W_n = 2.5\times10^{-3}$ µm, $W_p = 24.8$ µm, $\mathcal{E}_{max} = 384$ V/cm; (c) 75 times wider; it would reach the contact.)

Problem 5.4 The built-in voltage and temperature — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 3, Problem 3, p. 121

An abrupt silicon junction has $N_A = 10^{17}$ and $N_D = 10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$.

(a) Compute V_d at 250, 300, 350, 400, 450 and 500 K, using the expression of $n_i(T)$ of Problem 3.6 with $E_g = 1.12$ eV and $kT/q = 25.9\,(T/300)$ mV. Plot $V_d(T)$.

(b) Explain the trend with the band diagram: what happens to the Fermi levels of the two pieces apart as T rises?

(c) Up to which temperature are the dopings still the majority densities on both sides? What happens to V_d beyond?

(d) At 300 K compute W and $\mathcal{E}_{max}$.

(Answer: (a) 0.795, 0.716, 0.634, 0.550, 0.465, 0.379 V; (d) $W = 0.97$ µm, $\mathcal{E}_{max} = 1.5\times10^{4}$ V/cm.)

Problem 5.5 Which side controls the field? — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 7.15, p. 271

Silicon junctions at equilibrium, 300 K.

(a) With $N_A = 10^{17}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, compute V_d and $\mathcal{E}_{max}$ for $N_D = 10^{14}$, 10^{15}, 10^{16} and $10^{17}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$.

(b) Show that for $N_A \gg N_D$, $\mathcal{E}_{max} \simeq \sqrt{2qN_D V_d/\varepsilon}$. What does the field depend on?

(c) What can you say about the case $N_A = 10^{14}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$ and the same values of N_D?

(Answer: (a) $V_d = 0.656$, 0.716, 0.775, 0.835 V; $\mathcal{E}_{max} = 4.5\times10^{3}$, 1.5×10^{4}, 4.7×10^{4}, 1.1×10^{5} V/cm.)

Problem 5.6 How sharp are the edges of the SCR? C · Synthesis

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 7.14, p. 270

The depletion approximation assumes that the carriers vanish abruptly at the edges of the SCR. In reality the transition from the SCR to the neutral region takes a few Debye lengths, $L_D = \sqrt{\varepsilon kT/(q^2 N_D)}$ on the N side.

(a) Show that L_D is a length, and interpret it: over L_D, the potential changes by kT/q when the charge density is qN_D.

(b) With $N_A = 8\times10^{17}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$, compute L_D, W_n and the ratio L_D/W_n for $N_D = 8\times10^{14}$, 2.2×10^{16} and $8\times10^{17}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$.

(c) The ratio barely changes with the doping. Show that $L_D/W_n \simeq \sqrt{\frac{kT/q}{2V_d}}$ for a one-sided junction and explain why. Is the depletion approximation acceptable?

> **HINT**
> For a slab of charge density qN_D and thickness L, Poisson gives a potential drop $qN_DL^2/(2\varepsilon)$.

(Answer: (b) L_D = 0.145, 0.028, 0.0046 µm; W_n = 1.11, 0.220, 0.028 µm; ratios 0.13, 0.13, 0.17.)

> **Challenge: a new situation**
> These problems apply the method of the chapter to a device, a material or a situation that the chapter did not treat. The reasoning does not change: state the physical picture, choose the model, compute, check.

Problem 5.7 A junction without a change of type C · Synthesis

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 7.12, p. 270

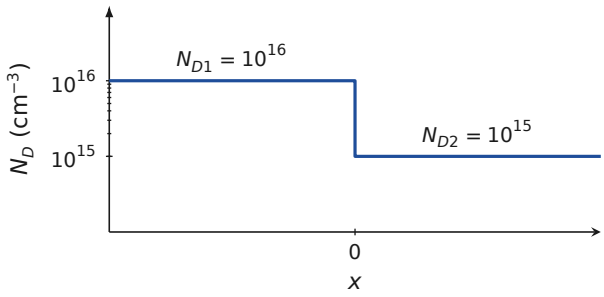
An 'isotype' junction joins two n regions of different doping: $N_{D1} = 10^{16}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$ for $x < 0$ and $N_{D2} = 10^{15}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$ for $x > 0$, at equilibrium.

(a) Sketch the band diagram of the two pieces apart and in contact. Find the built-in voltage between the two neutral regions. Which side is at the higher potential?

(b) Describe the charge near $x = 0$: on one side electrons have left, on the other they have accumulated. Why can there be no depletion approximation with a 'sharp edge' on the accumulation side?

(c) Estimate the width of the transition region with the Debye lengths of the two sides.

(d) Would this junction rectify? Use the barrier for the majority carriers to argue.



The isotype step. After Neamen, Fig. P7.12, p. 270.

> **HINT**
> The step of the bands is the difference of $E_C - E_F$ between the two pieces apart.

(Answer: (a) $V_{bi} = V_T \ln(N_{D1}/N_{D2}) = 59.6$ mV, the 10^{16} side positive; (c) about 0.04 to 0.13 µm; (d) no.)

Problem 5.8 The linearly graded junction

C · Synthesis

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 3, Problem 6, p. 121

In a diffused junction the net doping varies linearly through the junction: $N_D - N_A = ax$, with $a = 10^{20}$ cm^{-4}. Assume the depletion approximation on $-W/2 < x < W/2$.

(a) Write the charge density, integrate Poisson's equation and show that the field is parabolic, with $\mathcal{E}_{max} = qaW^2/(8\varepsilon)$ at $x = 0$.

(b) Integrate again and show that $V_d = qaW^3/(12\varepsilon)$, i.e. $W = (12\varepsilon V_d/qa)^{1/3}$.

(c) At the edges of the SCR the doping is $\pm aW/2$. Show that $V_d = \frac{2kT}{q} \ln \frac{aW}{2n_i}$.

(d) Solve (b) and (c) together by iteration, starting from $V_d = 0.7$ V. Give V_d, W and $\mathcal{E}_{max}$.

> **HINT**
> In (c), apply the formula of the abrupt junction to the dopings found at the two edges, $N_A = N_D = aW/2$.

(Answer: (d) $V_d = 0.668$ V, $W = 0.80$ µm, $\mathcal{E}_{max} = 1.25 \times 10^4$ V/cm.)

SEMICONDUCTOR DEVICES PHYSICS · EXERCISES

CHAPTER 6

The PN Junction Out of Equilibrium

WHAT THIS SET USES

The applied voltage drops across the SCR; low injection and quasi-equilibrium; quasi-Fermi levels, $n = n_i\,\mathrm{e}^{(E_{Fn}-E_i)/kT}$, $p = n_i\,\mathrm{e}^{(E_i-E_{Fp})/kT}$; the edge densities $n_p(x_p) = n_{p0}\mathrm{e}^{V/V_T}$, $p_n(x_n) = p_{n0}\mathrm{e}^{V/V_T}$; diffusion in the neutral regions; the Shockley law $J = J_0(\mathrm{e}^{V/V_T} - 1)$ with $J_0 = qn_i^2\left(\frac{D_n}{N_A d_p} + \frac{D_p}{N_D d_n}\right)$ for short regions and $d \to L$ for long regions; who carries the current; the solar cell and the LED.

DATA

Silicon at 300 K, $n_i = 10^{10}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$, $V_T = 25.9$ mV, $D_n = 35$, $D_p = 12$ cm²/s unless the problem gives other values. Reference diode: $N_A = 10^{18}$, $N_D = 10^{16}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$, $d_p = 2$ µm, $d_n = 10$ µm, $J_0 = 2.2\times10^{-11}$ A/cm². Low injection unless stated otherwise.

Problem 6.1 Reading the characteristic — A · Understanding

Adapted from Neamen, Problems 8.1 and 8.9, pp. 323–324, and Sze & Lee, Ch. 3, Problem 10, p. 121

An ideal diode follows $I = I_0(\mathrm{e}^{V/V_T} - 1)$ at 300 K.

(a) In forward bias ($V \gg V_T$), by how much must V increase to multiply the current by 10? By 100?

(b) At what reverse voltage does the reverse current reach 90 % of I_0? 95 %? 99 %?

(c) Explain physically, with the minority densities at the edges of the SCR, why the reverse current saturates after a few V_T, whatever the reverse voltage.

(Answer: (a) 59.6 mV and 119 mV; (b) −59.6, −77.6, −119 mV.)

Problem 6.2 Minority densities at the edges — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 8.2, p. 324

A silicon junction has $N_D = 2\times10^{15}$ and $N_A = 8\times10^{15}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$.

(a) Compute the equilibrium minority densities n_{p0} and p_{n0}.

(b) Compute the minority densities at the edges of the SCR for $V = 0.45$ V, 0.55 V and −0.55 V.

(c) At 0.55 V, compare $p_n(x_n)$ with N_D. Is low injection still satisfied?

(d) Check that at each edge $np = n_i^2\,\mathrm{e}^{V/V_T}$. What is the separation $E_{Fn} - E_{Fp}$ there?

(Answer: (a) $n_{p0} = 1.25\times10^4$, $p_{n0} = 5\times10^4\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$; (b) 0.45 V: 4.4×10^{11} and 1.8×10^{12}; 0.55 V: 2.1×10^{13} and 8.3×10^{13}; −0.55 V: 7×10^{-6} and $3\times10^{-5}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$; (c) 4 % of N_D: yes; (d) qV.)

Problem 6.3 The limit of low injection

B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 8.4, p. 324

A silicon diode has $N_D = 5\times10^{15}$ and $N_A = 5\times10^{16}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$. Low injection is taken to hold as long as the minority density at each edge does not exceed 10 % of the majority density on that side.

(a) Find the largest forward voltage allowed by each side. Which side sets the limit, and why?

(b) The neutral regions are short, $d_p = 2$ µm and $d_n = 10$ µm. Compute J_0 and the current density at the limit voltage.

(c) What changes in the diode when this limit is exceeded? Name two consequences.

> **HINT**
> On the N side, $p_{n0}\mathrm{e}^{V/V_T} \le 0.1\,N_D$.

(Answer: (a) N side 0.620 V, P side 0.739 V: the N side; (b) $J_0 = 9.5\times10^{-11}$ A/cm², $J = 2.4$ A/cm².)

Problem 6.4 A long diode

B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 3, Problems 12 and 13, pp. 121–122

An ideal silicon $\mathrm{N^+P}$ diode has $N_D = 10^{18}$ and $N_A = 10^{16}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, lifetimes $\tau_n = \tau_p = 1$ µs, and area 1.2×10^{-5} cm². Both neutral regions are much longer than the diffusion lengths. Take $D_n = 35$ cm²/s for the electrons in the P region and $D_p = 5$ cm²/s for the holes in the heavily doped N region.

(a) Compute L_n and L_p, and the minority profiles on each side in forward bias. Why do they decay exponentially, unlike those of the reference diode?

(b) Compute J_0, I_0, and the share of the current carried by electrons.

(c) Compute the current at +0.7 V and −0.7 V, and the voltage for 1 mA.

(d) If the P region were only 2 µm long (short), by what factor would the electron part of J_0 change? Explain with the gradient of the electron profile.

(Answer: (a) $L_n = 59$ µm, $L_p = 22$ µm; (b) $J_0 = 9.5\times10^{-12}$ A/cm², $I_0 = 1.1\times10^{-16}$ A, 99.6 % electrons; (c) 62 µA and -1.1×10^{-16} A, 0.772 V; (d) ×29.6.)

Problem 6.5 Choosing who carries the current

B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 8.11, p. 324

A silicon diode has the geometry of the reference diode, $d_p = 2$ µm and $d_n = 10$ µm, both short.

(a) Show that $J_n/J_p = \dfrac{D_n}{D_p}\dfrac{N_D}{N_A}\dfrac{d_n}{d_p}$. Evaluate it for the reference diode and check the share of 87 % for holes given in the course.

(b) What ratio N_D/N_A makes electrons carry 90 % of the current?

(c) What ratio N_D/N_A makes holes carry 80 % of the current?

(d) Which design choice of the bipolar transistor of Chapter 8 uses this result?

> **HINT**
> Each term of J_0 is the current of the minority carriers of one side.

(Answer: (a) 0.146, holes 87.3 %; (b) 0.62; (c) 0.017.)

Problem 6.6 The diode as a thermometer

B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problems 8.21 and 8.26, pp. 326–327

Assume that J_0 depends on temperature only through $n_i^2 \propto T^3 \mathrm{e}^{-E_g/kT}$, with $E_g = 1.12$ eV constant.

(a) By what factor does J_0 increase from 300 to 310 K? From 300 to 400 K?

(b) A silicon diode is biased at a constant current; at 300 K its voltage is 0.600 V. Show that $V(T) = \frac{kT}{q}\left[\frac{0.600}{0.0259} - \ln\frac{J_0(T)}{J_0(300)}\right]$ and compute V at 310 K and 320 K.

(c) Deduce the temperature coefficient in mV/K. Why does the voltage decrease although kT/q increases?

(Answer: (a) 4.5 and 1.2×10^5; (b) 0.580 and 0.560 V; (c) about −2.0 mV/K.)

Problem 6.7 Quasi-Fermi levels in a short region

C · Synthesis

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 6.37, p. 238

Consider the N region of the reference diode ($N_D = 10^{16}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$, $d_n = 10$ µm, short) at $V = +0.5$ V. Let y be the distance from the edge x_n, $0 \le y \le d_n$.

(a) Write the hole density $p(y)$, from the edge value to the equilibrium value at the contact.

(b) Show that $E_{Fn} - E_{Fp} = kT\ln[p(y)/p_{n0}]$ in this region, and compute it at $y = 0$, $d_n/2$, $0.9\,d_n$ and $0.99\,d_n$. Sketch $E_{Fp}(y)$.

(c) The hole current is $J_p = \mu_p p\,\mathrm{d}E_{Fp}/\mathrm{d}y$. Using your profile, explain why the slope of E_{Fp} is small near the edge and large near the contact, although J_p is the same everywhere.

(d) Why is E_{Fn} practically flat in the same region?

> **HINT**
> In the N region E_{Fn} stays at the level of the majority electrons; $p = n_i\,\mathrm{e}^{(E_i - E_{Fp})/kT}$ and $n = N_D = n_i\,\mathrm{e}^{(E_{Fn} - E_i)/kT}$.

(Answer: (b) 0.500, 0.482, 0.440, 0.381 eV.)

Challenge: a new situation
These problems apply the method of the chapter to a device, a material or a situation that the chapter did not treat. The reasoning does not change: state the physical picture, choose the model, compute, check.

Problem 6.8 A germanium diode

C · Synthesis

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 8.7, p. 324

An ideal germanium diode at 300 K has $N_A = 4\times10^{15}$ and $N_D = 2\times10^{17}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $D_n = 90$ and $D_p = 48$ cm²/s, $\tau_n = \tau_p = 2$ µs, area 10^{-4} cm², and long neutral regions. For germanium $n_i = 2.4\times10^{13}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$.

(a) Compute L_n, L_p, J_0 and I_0.

(b) Compute the current at +0.25 V and −0.25 V.

(c) Compare J_0 with that of a silicon diode of the same design. Explain the ratio with n_i and the gap, and say why germanium diodes conduct at lower voltage but leak more.

(Answer: (a) $L_n = 134$ µm, $L_p = 98$ µm, $J_0 = 1.6\times10^{-4}$ A/cm², $I_0 = 1.6\times10^{-8}$ A; (b) 0.24 mA and −16 nA; (c) $(2.4\times10^{13}/10^{10})^2 = 5.8\times10^6$ times larger.)

Problem 6.9 Open-circuit voltage of an illuminated diode

C · Synthesis

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 8.36, p. 328

A long silicon diode has $N_D = 10^{18}$, $N_A = 3\times10^{16}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $\tau_n = \tau_p = 0.1$ µs, $D_n = 18$ and $D_p = 6$ cm²/s. Light absorbed in and near the SCR produces a photocurrent density $J_{ph} = 25$ mA/cm². The diode is open-circuited.

(a) Explain why the photocurrent forward biases the junction when no current can leave the device.

(b) Compute J_0, then V_{oc} from $J = J_0(\text{e}^{V/V_T} - 1) - J_{ph} = 0$.

(c) With the device connected to a load, the power delivered is $P = V(J_{ph} - J_0(\text{e}^{V/V_T} - 1))$ per cm². Find its maximum numerically, and the fill factor $P_{max}/(V_{oc}J_{ph})$.

(Answer: (b) $J_0 = 7.3\times10^{-12}$ A/cm², $V_{oc} = 0.569$ V; (c) $P_{max} = 11.7$ mW/cm² at 0.491 V, fill factor 0.82.)

SEMICONDUCTOR DEVICES PHYSICS · EXERCISES

CHAPTER 7

The Capacitance Effects of the Junction

WHAT THIS SET USES

The SCR under reverse bias, $W = \sqrt{\frac{2\varepsilon(V_d - V)}{q}\frac{N_A + N_D}{N_A N_D}}$; the transition capacitance $C_T = \varepsilon S/W$; the $1/C_T^2$ plot; the varicap; the stored minority charge $Q = \bar{\tau}_{tr} I$ (transit time $d^2/2D$ for a short region, lifetime for a long one); the diffusion capacitance $C_D = (q/kT)\,\bar{\tau}_{tr} I$; the small-signal diode, $r_d = kT/qI$ in parallel with C_T and C_D; the storage time on switching off, of the order of $\bar{\tau}_{tr} I_F / I_R$.

DATA

Silicon at 300 K, $n_i = 10^{10}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $V_T = 25.9$ mV, $\varepsilon = 1.036 \times 10^{-12}$ F/cm, $D_p = 12$ cm²/s. Reference diode: P^+N, $N_A = 10^{18}$, $N_D = 10^{16}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $S = 10^{-4}$ cm², $V_d = 0.835$ V, $C_{T0} = 3.15$ pF.

Problem 7.1 Capacitance of a reverse-biased junction

B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 7.24, p. 272

A silicon junction has $N_A = 2 \times 10^{15}$, $N_D = 4 \times 10^{16}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$ and area 5×10^{-4} cm².

(a) Compute V_d.

(b) Compute W and C_T at $V = 0$ and at $V = -5$ V.

(c) By what factor does C_T fall? Why is it not $\sqrt{5/0.71}$?

(d) Explain, with the picture of the charges at the edges of the SCR, why $C_T = \varepsilon S/W$ although the charge is spread over the whole SCR.

(Answer: (a) 0.710 V; (b) 0.694 µm, 7.46 pF; 1.97 µm, 2.63 pF; (c) 2.84.)

Problem 7.2 Halving the capacitance

B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 7.23, p. 272

A silicon junction has $N_A = 2 \times 10^{16}$ and $N_D = 5 \times 10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$. At a reverse voltage of 0.5 V its capacitance is 1.5 times its value at a larger reverse voltage V_{R2}.

(a) Show that $C_T(V_{R1})/C_T(V_{R2}) = \sqrt{(V_d + V_{R2})/(V_d + V_{R1})}$.

(b) Compute V_d and V_{R2}.

(c) What reverse voltage would halve the capacitance obtained at 0.5 V? Comment on the cost, in volts, of tuning by a factor 2.

(Answer: (b) $V_d = 0.716$ V, $V_{R2} = 2.02$ V; (c) 4.15 V.)

Problem 7.3 Tuning a resonant circuit

B · Guided calculation

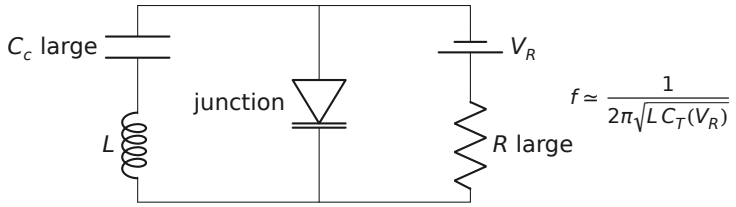
Adapted from Neamen, Problem 7.25, p. 272

An abrupt silicon junction ($N_A = 2\times10^{17}$, $N_D = 5\times10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, area 8×10^{-4} cm²) is placed in parallel with an inductance L. At a reverse voltage of 10 V the resonant frequency is 1.25 MHz.

(a) Compute C_T at 10 V and deduce L.

(b) Compute the resonant frequency at reverse voltages of 1 V and 5 V.

(c) Over the range 1–10 V, by what factor does the frequency change? Express the dependence of f on V_R for this junction.



A varicap tuning circuit (the capacitor C_c blocks the bias, the resistor isolates the source).

(Answer: (a) 4.90 pF, $L = 3.31$ mH; (b) 0.796 MHz and 1.07 MHz; (c) 1.57, $f \propto (V_d + V_R)^{1/4}$.)

Problem 7.4 Measuring a junction with $1/C^2$

B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 7.30, p. 273

A silicon junction has $N_A = 2\times10^{17}$, $N_D = 2\times10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$ and area 10^{-5} cm².

(a) Compute V_d and C_T at reverse voltages of 1, 3 and 5 V.

(b) Compute $1/C_T^2$ at these voltages. Show that it is a straight line in V_R and give its slope.

(c) Pretend that you only know the measured points. Deduce N_D from the slope (one-sided junction) and V_d from the intercept with the voltage axis. Compare with the true values.

> **HINT**
> $1/C_T^2 = W^2/(\varepsilon S)^2 = \dfrac{2(V_d + V_R)}{q\varepsilon S^2}\dfrac{N_A + N_D}{N_A N_D}$.

(Answer: (a) 0.752 V; 96.9, 66.2, 53.5 fF; (b) $1/C^2 = 1.07,\ 2.28,\ 3.50\times10^{26}$ F^{-2}, slope 6.09×10^{25} F^{-2}V^{-1}; (c) $N_D = 1.98\times10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, intercept -0.752 V.)

Problem 7.5 Charge stored in a thin neutral region — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 3, Problem 15, p. 122

An abrupt silicon P^+N junction has $N_D = 10^{16}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$. It is forward biased at 0.7 V. The neutral N region is 1 µm long and the hole diffusion length is 5 µm.

(a) Is the N region short or long? Write the hole excess at the edge and sketch its profile.

(b) Compute the stored hole charge per unit area with the straight-line profile.

(c) The exact profile is $\Delta p(y) = \Delta p_0 \sinh[(d-y)/L_p]/\sinh(d/L_p)$. Integrate it and compare with (b).

(d) Compute the hole current density and the ratio Q/J. Check that it is the transit time $d^2/2D_p$.

(Answer: (a) short; (b) 4.38×10^{-8} C/cm²; (c) 0.3 % less; (d) J = 105 A/cm², 0.42 ns.)

Problem 7.6 Diffusion capacitance and the small-signal impedance — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problems 8.39 and 8.41, p. 328

For a forward-biased diode the measured diffusion capacitance grows linearly with the current, with a slope $\mathrm{d}C_D/\mathrm{d}I = 2.5\times10^{-6}$ F/A.

(a) With $C_D = (q/kT)\,\bar{\tau}_{tr} I$, find $\bar{\tau}_{tr}$.

(b) At I = 1 mA, compute C_D and r_d. Neglect C_T.

(c) Compute the modulus and phase of the impedance of $r_d \parallel C_D$ at 10 kHz, 100 kHz, 1 MHz and 10 MHz. Above which frequency is the diode mainly capacitive?

(d) Show that this corner frequency, $1/(2\pi r_d C_D)$, depends only on $\bar{\tau}_{tr}$, not on the current.

(Answer: (a) 65 ns; (b) 2.5 nF, 25.9 Ω; (c) 25.9 Ω/−0.2°, 25.9 Ω/−2.3°, 24.0 Ω/−22°, 6.2 Ω/−76°; corner 2.46 MHz.)

Problem 7.7 How good is the storage-time estimate? — C · Synthesis

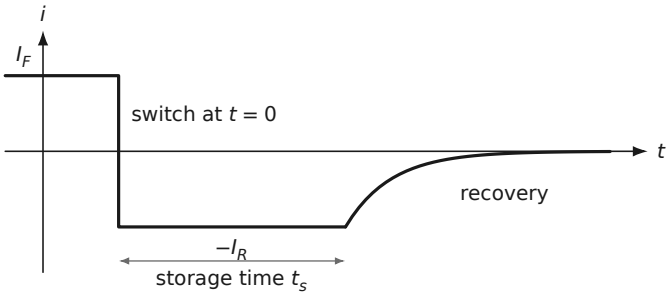
Adapted from Neamen, Problem 8.47, p. 328

A long diode with hole lifetime τ_p carries a forward current I_F and is switched to a reverse current I_R. The course estimates the storage time by $t_s \approx \tau_p I_F/I_R$, an upper bound. A full solution of the diffusion equation for a long region gives $\operatorname{erf}\sqrt{t_s/\tau_p} = I_F/(I_F+I_R)$.

(a) Explain why $\tau_p I_F/I_R$ is an upper bound: which ways out of the neutral region does it ignore?

(b) Compute t_s/τ_p from the exact relation for $I_R/I_F = 0.2$ and $I_R/I_F = 1$, and compare with the estimate.

(c) A rectifier with τ_p = 10 µs is switched with $I_R = I_F$. Estimate its storage time. What could be done to reduce it by a factor 1000?



Switching a diode off: the current stays at $-I_R$ while the stored charge is removed, then recovers.

> **HINT**
> erf(0.975) = 0.833 and erf(0.477) = 0.500.

(Answer: (b) 0.95 against 5; 0.23 against 1; (c) about 2.3 µs.)

> **Challenge: a new situation**
> These problems apply the method of the chapter to a device, a material or a situation that the chapter did not treat. The reasoning does not change: state the physical picture, choose the model, compute, check.

Problem 7.8 When the SCR reaches the contact

C · Synthesis

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 3, Problem 16, p. 122

A silicon P^+N diode has $N_A = 10^{19}$ and $N_D = 10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, but its N region is only 5 µm thick before a heavily doped N^+ contact layer. Area 10^{-4} cm².

(a) At what reverse voltage does the SCR reach the N^+ layer ('punch-through' of the N region)? What is then the maximum field?

(b) Sketch $C_T(V_R)$ below and above this voltage. What is the capacitance above it?

(c) Above punch-through, the extra reverse voltage cannot widen the SCR. Show that it adds a uniform field $\Delta V/5\ \mu$m, and draw the field profile. Why does this design raise the voltage a diode can block for a given maximum field?

(d) In which device of Chapter 8 is punch-through of a region a failure mode, and why?

(Answer: (a) $V_R = 18.5$ V, $\mathcal{E}_{max} = 7.7 \times 10^4$ V/cm; (b) constant, 0.207 pF.)

SEMICONDUCTOR DEVICES PHYSICS · EXERCISES

CHAPTER 8

The Bipolar Junction Transistor

WHAT THIS SET USES

The two junctions sharing a short base; the straight-line electron profile and $I_C = qSD_n n(0)/W_B = I_S e^{V_{BE}/V_T}$ with $I_S = qSD_n n_i^2/(N_B W_B)$; the emitter efficiency γ, the transport factor $\alpha_T = 1 - W_B^2/2L_n^2$ (expansion of $1/\cosh(W_B/L_n)$), $\alpha_F = \gamma\alpha_T$, $1/\beta_F = \frac{D_p}{D_n}\frac{N_B}{N_E}\frac{W_B}{d_E} + \frac{W_B^2}{2L_n^2}$; the stored charge $Q_B = \tau_B I_C$ with $\tau_B = W_B^2/2D_n$; the four operating regions and the Ebers–Moll superposition; base-width modulation, $V_{A,loc} = Q_{B,maj}/C_{jc}$, $r_o = V_{A,loc}/I_C$; $g_m = I_C/V_T$, $C_\pi = g_m\tau_F + C_{je}$, $1/(2\pi f_T) = \tau_F + (C_{je} + C_\mu)/g_m$, $f_T = \beta_0 f_\beta$.

DATA

Silicon at 300 K, $n_i = 10^{10}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $V_T = 25.9$ mV, $\varepsilon = 1.036 \times 10^{-12}$ F/cm. Reference NPN transistor: $N_E = 10^{18}$, $N_B = 10^{16}$, $N_C = 10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; $d_E = 0.5$ µm; $W_B = 1$ µm at $V_{CB} = 5$ V; $S = 10^{-4}$ cm²; $D_n = 35$, $D_p = 12$ cm²/s, $\tau_n = 0.1$ µs; $I_S = 5.6 \times 10^{-14}$ A, $\beta_F = 121$, $\beta_R = 2.9$, $\tau_B = 0.143$ ns. Where a problem gives its own diffusivities or lifetimes (those of the textbook), use them.

Problem 8.1 The bands of a PNP transistor in its four regions A · Understanding

Adapted from Neamen, Problems 12.1 and 12.2, pp. 560–561

The course develops the NPN transistor. Consider instead a uniformly doped P^+NP transistor (emitter P^+, base N, collector P, more lightly doped than the base). Sketch, one below the other and on the same horizontal axis, the band diagram (E_C, E_V and the Fermi level or the two quasi-Fermi levels) and the field $\mathcal{E}(x)$:

(a) at thermal equilibrium;

(b) in forward-active operation ($V_{EB} > 0$, $V_{CB} < 0$);

(c) in inverse-active operation ($V_{EB} < 0$, $V_{CB} > 0$);

(d) in cut-off, both junctions reverse biased.

(e) In each case, say which carriers cross the base and in which direction, and compare with the NPN of the course: what changes, and what does not?

HINT

Start from the equilibrium picture: E_F is flat, close to E_V in the P regions and close to E_C in the N base. Then remember Chapter 6: a forward bias V lowers a barrier by qV, a reverse bias raises it.

(Answer: The base bands lie lower than those of the emitter and collector (a well for electrons, a hill for holes); forward-active: low EB barrier, high BC barrier, holes cross the base from emitter to collector; inverse-active: the roles of the junctions are exchanged; cut-off: both barriers high, only leakage currents. The field points from the base towards each outer region at equilibrium.)

Problem 8.2 Gains and the open-base current — A · Understanding

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 4, Problems 1 and 2, p. 157

An NPN transistor has a transport factor $\alpha_T = 0.998$ and an emitter efficiency $\gamma = 0.997$. When the emitter is left open, the reverse-biased BC junction carries a leakage current $I_{CBO} = 10$ nA (the reverse current of Chapter 6, generation in the BC SCR included).

(a) Compute α_F and β_F.

(b) In forward-active operation the collector receives the fraction α_F of the emitter current *plus* the leakage: $I_C = \alpha_F I_E + I_{CBO}$. The base is now left open ($I_B = 0$). Show that $I_E = I_C = I_{CBO}/(1-\alpha_F)$ and compute it. Explain physically why the base must be forward biased although no current enters it.

(c) A second transistor has $\gamma = 0.999$, $\alpha_T \approx 1$ and $I_{CBO} = 10$ µA (a power device at high temperature). With $I_B = 0$, compute I_E and the part of it carried by holes injected into the emitter. Compare this hole current with I_{CBO} and explain the coincidence.

(d) Why must the base of a transistor never be left floating in a circuit?

> **HINT**
> With $I_B = 0$, every hole that leaves the base must be supplied from inside the device. Which holes enter the base, and which ones leave it?

(Answer: (a) $\alpha_F = 0.9950$, $\beta_F = 199$; (b) $I_E = 2.0$ µA $= (\beta_F + 1) I_{CBO}$; (c) $I_E = 10$ mA, holes 10 µA $= I_{CBO}$.)

Problem 8.3 The saturation current from the base parameters — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problems 12.3 and 12.4, p. 561

The base of a silicon NPN transistor has $D_n = 18$ cm²/s, $n_{B0} = 4\times10^{3}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$ and a neutral width $W_B = 0.80$ µm; the EB area is $S = 5\times10^{-5}$ cm².

(a) Compare $I_C = qSD_n n(0)/W_B$ with $I_C = I_S \mathrm{e}^{V_{BE}/V_T}$ and compute I_S. What is the base doping, with the course value of n_i?

(b) Compute I_C at $V_{BE} = 0.58$, 0.65 and 0.72 V. By how much must V_{BE} increase to multiply I_C by 10?

(c) For each point, compute $n(0)/N_B$. Up to which point is the low-injection model valid?

(d) A second transistor has $D_n = 22$ cm²/s, $W_B = 0.80$ µm and $n_{B0} = 2\times10^{4}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$. What area gives $I_C = 2$ mA at $V_{BE} = 0.60$ V? With this area, what V_{BE} gives 5 mA?

(Answer: (a) $I_S = 7.2\times10^{-15}$ A, $N_B = 2.5\times10^{16}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; (b) 38.3 µA, 0.572 mA, 8.53 mA; 59.6 mV per decade; (c) 0.09 %, 1.3 %, 19 %; (d) $S = 1.97\times10^{-4}$ cm², 0.624 V.)

Problem 8.4 The current components of a PNP transistor B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 4, Problems 3, 4 and 5, pp. 157–158

A silicon PNP transistor has $N_E = 5\times10^{18}$, $N_B = 2\times10^{17}$ and $N_C = 10^{16}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, a metallurgical base width of 1.0 µm and an area $S = 0.2$ mm². The EB junction is forward biased at $V_{EB} = 0.5$ V and the BC junction reverse biased at 5 V. The minority-carrier diffusivities given by the textbook are 52, 40 and 115 cm²/s in the emitter, base and collector, and the lifetimes 10^{-8}, 10^{-7} and 10^{-6} s. The emitter and the collector are thick: treat them as long regions.

(a) Compute V_{dE}, V_{dC}, the widths of the two SCRs and the part of each in the base. Deduce the neutral base width W_B.

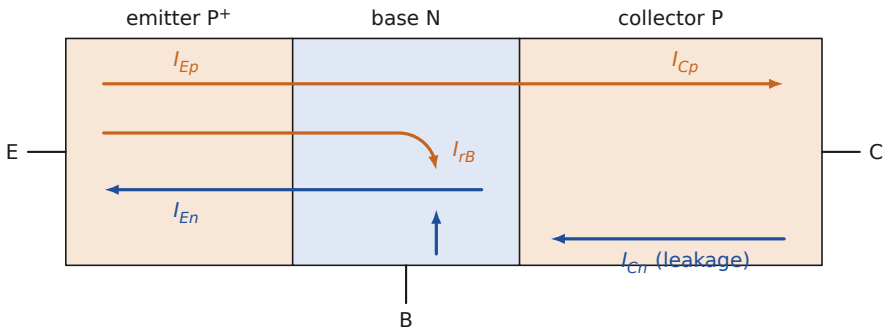
(b) Compute p_{B0}, n_{E0}, n_{C0} and the hole density $p(0)$ at the emitter edge of the neutral base.

(c) Compute the three diffusion lengths. Is the base short? Sketch the minority-carrier profiles in the three regions.

(d) Compute the current components: I_{Ep} (holes injected into the base), I_{rB} (holes recombining in the base, with Q_B/τ), $I_{Cp} = I_{Ep} - I_{rB}$, I_{En} (electrons injected into the emitter) and I_{Cn} (electrons extracted from the collector by the reverse-biased BC junction).

(e) Deduce I_E, I_C, I_B, then γ, α_T, α_F and β_F.

(f) Which loss limits the gain? Propose two changes of design that would improve it.



The current components of a PNP transistor in forward-active operation. After Sze & Lee, Ch. 4, Fig. 5, p. 128.

HINT

For a PNP, $p(0) = p_{B0}e^{V_{EB}/V_T}$. In a long emitter, the injected electron current is $qSD_E n_{E0}(e^{V_{EB}/V_T} - 1)/L_E$ (Chapter 6). I_{Cn} is the reverse current of a long N…P side: $qSD_C n_{C0}/L_C$.

(Answer: (a) $V_{dE} = 0.954$ V, $V_{dC} = 0.793$ V; 0.0553 µm (0.053 in the base), 0.887 µm (0.042 in the base); $W_B = 0.905$ µm; (b) $p_{B0} = 500$, $n_{E0} = 20$, $n_{C0} = 10^4$, $p(0) = 1.21\times10^{11}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; (c) 7.2, 20, 107 µm, $W_B/L_B = 0.045$; (d) $I_{Ep} = 17.15$ µA, $I_{rB} = 17.5$ nA, $I_{Cp} = 17.13$ µA, $I_{En} = 0.112$ µA, $I_{Cn} = 3.4\times10^{-14}$ A; (e) $I_E = 17.26$ µA, $I_C = 17.13$ µA, $I_B = 0.129$ µA, $\gamma = 0.9935$, $\alpha_T = 0.99898$, $\alpha_F = 0.9925$, $\beta_F = 132$.)

Problem 8.5 The base as a charge reservoir — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 4, Problems 8 and 9, p. 158

Use the PNP transistor of Problem 8.4 in forward-active operation.

(a) With the straight-line hole profile, show that the stored excess charge is $Q_B = \frac{1}{2} q S p(0) W_B$, the area of a triangle. Compute it.

(b) Show that $I_C \simeq 2 D_B Q_B / W_B^2$, check it numerically, and deduce the transit time $\tau_B = Q_B / I_C$.

(c) Show that the recombination current is $I_{rB} = Q_B / \tau$ and that $\alpha_T = 1 - \tau_B / \tau$. Give a picture of the base that makes these two results obvious.

(d) The collector current is to be switched off in a time much shorter than τ_B. What base current must flow briefly, and why can it not be obtained by simply opening the base?

(Answer: (a) 1.75×10^{-15} C; (b) 17.1 µA, $\tau_B = 0.102$ ns; (c) $\alpha_T = 1 - 1.0 \times 10^{-3}$.)

Problem 8.6 Which loss limits the gain? — A · Understanding

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 12.27, p. 564

The two losses of the course are the transport loss in the base and the injection loss into the emitter.

(a) Compute the transport factor $\alpha_T = 1/\cosh(W_B/L_n)$ for $W_B/L_n = 0.01$, 0.1, 1 and 10, and compare with $1 - W_B^2/2L_n^2$. Taking $\gamma = 1$, deduce β_F in each case.

(b) Take a transistor with $D_E = D_B$ and $d_E = W_B$ (short regions), so that $\gamma = 1/(1 + N_B/N_E)$. Compute γ for $N_B/N_E = 0.01$, 0.1, 1 and 10 and, taking $\alpha_T = 1$, β_F.

(c) What do you conclude: which ratio controls each loss, and how large must it be for a useful gain of about 100?

(Answer: (a) $\alpha_T = 0.99995$, 0.9950, 0.648, 9.1×10^{-5}; $\beta_F = 2.0 \times 10^4$, 200, 1.84, 9×10^{-5}; (b) $\gamma = 0.990$, 0.909, 0.5, 0.091; $\beta_F = 100$, 10, 1, 0.1.)

Problem 8.7 Designing for a current gain of 150 — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 12.29, p. 565

A silicon NPN transistor is to have $\beta_F = 150$. The data are $D_B = 23$ and $D_E = 8$ cm²/s, the lifetimes $\tau_B = 2{\times}10^{-7}$ s in the base and $\tau_E = 8{\times}10^{-8}$ s in the emitter, $N_B = 2{\times}10^{16}$ cm^{-3} and an emitter width $d_E = 0.35$ µm. The technology cannot make a neutral base narrower than 0.80 µm. The course model neglects recombination in the EB SCR; here it is not negligible, and it is described by a third factor $\delta = 0.9975$, so that $\alpha_F = \gamma\, \alpha_T\, \delta$.

(a) Compute L_B and L_E. Are the base and the emitter short?

(b) Which base width should be chosen, and why? Compute α_T.

(c) Compute the required α_F, then the required γ, and the minimum emitter doping N_E.

(d) Check your design by recomputing β_F with N_E rounded to 5×10^{18} cm^{-3}. Which of the three losses is now the largest?

(Answer: (a) $L_B = 21.4$ µm, $L_E = 8.0$ µm, both short; (b) $W_B = 0.80$ µm, $\alpha_T = 0.99930$; (c) $\alpha_F = 0.99338$, $\gamma = 0.99656$, $N_E \geq 4.6 \times 10^{18}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; (d) $\beta_F = 156$.)

Problem 8.8 The transistor used backwards — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 12.19, p. 563

A silicon NPN transistor has $N_E = 10^{19}$, $N_B = 10^{17}$, $N_C = 7 \times 10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$ and a metallurgical base width of 1.2 µm. It operates in the inverse-active region with $V_{BE} = -2$ V and $V_{BC} = 0.565$ V.

(a) Sketch the minority-carrier densities through the device.

(b) Compute the minority-carrier densities at the two edges of the neutral base, at the edge of the neutral collector and at the edge of the neutral emitter.

(c) Compute the two SCR widths, the part of each in the base and the neutral base width.

(d) Compare the electron density injected into the base by the BC junction with the hole density injected into the collector. Use this to explain why β_R is small, and why it cannot be improved without spoiling the forward operation.

(Answer: (b) $n(W_B) = 3.0 \times 10^{12}$, $n(0) \approx 0$, $p_C = 4.3 \times 10^{13}$, $p_E \approx 0\,\text{cm}^{-3}$; (c) EB 0.196 µm (0.195 in the base), BC 0.199 µm (0.013 in the base), $W_B = 0.99$ µm; (d) ratio 14.)

Problem 8.9 Charges stored in saturation — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Neamen, Problem 12.18, p. 563

A silicon NPN transistor has $N_E = 10^{18}$, $N_B = 5 \times 10^{16}$ and $N_C = 10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, $D_n = 25$ cm²/s in the base, a neutral base width $W_B = 0.70$ µm much shorter than L_n, and a long collector with hole diffusion length $L_C = 35$ µm. It operates in saturation with an electron current density $J_n = 125$ A/cm² across the base and $V_{BE} = 0.72$ V. (With the course value of n_i, the textbook value $V_{BE} = 0.70$ V could not carry this current at all, even with $V_{BC} = 0$: check it.)

(a) In saturation both junctions inject. Write the straight-line profile between $n(0)$ and $n(W_B)$ and show that $J_n = \frac{qD_n n_{B0}}{W_B}\left(\text{e}^{V_{BE}/V_T} - \text{e}^{V_{BC}/V_T}\right)$. Compute V_{BC}.

(b) Compute V_{CE}.

(c) Compute the number of excess electrons per cm² in the base, and compare with forward-active operation at the same V_{BE}.

(d) Compute the hole density injected at the edge of the neutral collector and the number of excess holes per cm² stored in the long collector. Is low injection valid there?

(e) Compare (c) and (d). What does this imply for the time needed to switch the transistor off?

(Answer: (a) $V_{BC} = 0.654$ V; (b) $V_{CE} = 66$ mV; (c) 8.9×10^{10} cm^{-2} (8.3×10^{10} forward-active); (d) $9.1 \times 10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, 3.2×10^{13} cm^{-2}, no; (e) about 350 times more charge in the collector.)

Problem 8.10 Early voltage: from data and from the physics calculation — B · Guided

Adapted from Neamen, Problems 12.35 and 12.37, p. 566

(a) A transistor carries $I_C = 1.2$ mA at $V_{CE} = 2$ V, and its Early voltage (the extrapolated intercept of the output line) is $V_A = 120$ V. Compute r_o and $g_o = 1/r_o$ with $r_o = V_A/I_C$, and the collector current at $V_{CE} = 4$ V. Repeat for $I_C = 0.25$ mA and $V_A = 160$ V.

(b) A silicon NPN transistor has $N_E = 2\times10^{18}$, $N_B = 2\times10^{16}$, $N_C = 2\times10^{15}\,\text{cm}^{-3}$, a metallurgical base width of 0.85 µm and $D_n = 25$ cm²/s. $V_{BE} = 0.650$ V. Compute the part of the EB SCR in the base, then, for $V_{CB} = 4$, 8 and 12 V, the part of the BC SCR in the base, W_B and $J_C = qD_n n(0)/W_B$.

(c) Estimate the Early voltage from the points at 4 and 12 V (extend the line to $J_C = 0$).

(d) Compute $V_{A,loc} = Q_{B,maj}/C_{jc}$ at $V_{CB} = 8$ V and compare. Explain the difference with the relation $V_{A,loc} = V_A + V_{CE}$ of the course.

(Answer: (a) 100 kΩ, 10 µS, 1.22 mA; 640 kΩ, 1.56 µS, 0.253 mA; (b) 0.119 µm; $W_B = 0.565$, 0.505, 0.458 µm; $J_C = 28.1$, 31.4, 34.7 A/cm²; (c) $V_A \approx 30$ V; (d) 38.8 V ≈ 30 + 8.65.)

Problem 8.11 Base width for a given transition frequency — B · Guided calculation

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 4, Problems 23 and 24, p. 159

In this problem the emitter and collector delays are neglected, so that $\tau_F \simeq \tau_B = W_B^2/2D$.

(a) A silicon PNP transistor has $D_p = 10$ cm²/s in the base, $W_B = 0.5$ µm and $\alpha_F = 0.998$. Compute τ_B, the upper limit $f_T = 1/(2\pi\tau_B)$, β_0 and $f_\beta = f_T/\beta_0$.

(b) What base width gives an upper limit of 5 GHz with the same D_p?

(c) The transistor of (b) has $C_{je} + C_\mu = 2$ pF. Use $1/(2\pi f_T) = \tau_F + (C_{je} + C_\mu)/g_m$ to compute f_T at 1 mA and 10 mA. At what current does f_T reach 4 GHz?

(d) Why would an NPN transistor of the same base width be faster?

(Answer: (a) 0.125 ns, 1.27 GHz, $\beta_0 = 499$, $f_\beta = 2.55$ MHz; (b) 0.25 µm; (c) 1.9 GHz, 4.3 GHz; 6.5 mA.)

Challenge: a new situation
These problems apply the method of the chapter to a device, a material or a situation that the chapter did not treat. The reasoning does not change: state the physical picture, choose the model, compute, check.

Problem 8.12 An implanted base with a built-in field

C · Synthesis

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 4, Problems 16 and 17, p. 158

In a real NPN transistor the base is made by implantation, and its doping decreases from the emitter to the collector: $N(x) = N_{A0}\mathrm{e}^{-x/\ell}$ with $N_{A0} = 2\times10^{18}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$ and $\ell = 0.3\,\mu\mathrm{m}$, over a neutral base of width $W_B = 0.8\,\mu\mathrm{m}$ ($x = 0$ at the emitter side).

(a) Compute the number of acceptors per cm² in the neutral base, $Q_G = \int_0^{W_B} N\,\mathrm{d}x$ (the 'Gummel number'), and the average doping.

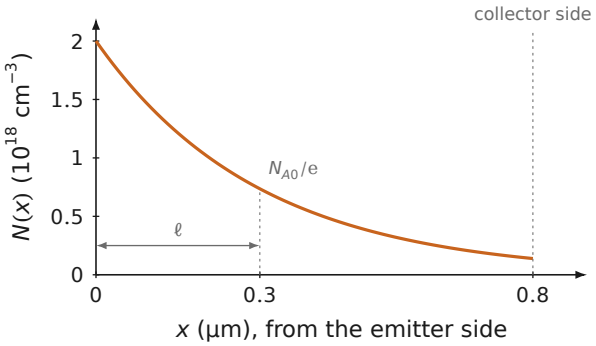
(b) In equilibrium, and approximately under low injection, the hole current in the base is zero. Use the drift–diffusion expression of the hole current (Chapters 1 and 4) to show that there is a built-in field $\mathcal{E} = \frac{kT}{q}\frac{1}{N}\frac{\mathrm{d}N}{\mathrm{d}x}$. Compute it, give its direction and show that it pushes electrons towards the collector.

(c) Write the electron current $J_n = q\mu_n n\mathcal{E} + qD_n\mathrm{d}n/\mathrm{d}x$ with this field and show that it can be written $J_n = \frac{qD_n}{N}\frac{\mathrm{d}(nN)}{\mathrm{d}x}$. Integrate across the base (with $nN = n_i^2\mathrm{e}^{V_{BE}/V_T}$ at $x = 0$ and $n \approx 0$ at W_B) to obtain

$$|J_n| = \frac{qD_n n_i^2}{Q_G}\,\mathrm{e}^{V_{BE}/V_T}.$$

Check that it reduces to the course formula for a uniform base.

(d) The textbook gives, at 300 K, $\mu_n = 88 + 1252/(1 + 0.698\times10^{-17}N)$ cm²/(V·s). Compute D_n for the average doping. The emitter is long, with $L_E = 1\,\mu\mathrm{m}$, $N_E = 10^{19}\,\mathrm{cm}^{-3}$, $D_E = 1$ cm²/s, and the base lifetime is 10^{-6} s. Estimate γ, α_T (uniform-base formula, a slight underestimate) and β_F.



The implanted base doping.

HINT

(c) $\mu_n\mathcal{E} = D_n\frac{1}{N}\frac{\mathrm{d}N}{\mathrm{d}x}$ by Einstein's relation, so $J_n = qD_n\left(\frac{\mathrm{d}n}{\mathrm{d}x} + \frac{n}{N}\frac{\mathrm{d}N}{\mathrm{d}x}\right)$.

(Answer: (a) $Q_G = 5.6\times10^{13}$ cm^{-2}, average 7.0×10^{17} cm^{-3}; (b) 863 V/cm, pointing towards the emitter; (d) $\mu_n = 301$ cm²/(V·s), $D_n = 7.8$ cm²/s, $\gamma = 0.9929$, $\alpha_T = 0.99959$, $\beta_F \approx 132$.)

Problem 8.13 A silicon–germanium base

C · Synthesis

Adapted from Sze & Lee, Ch. 4, Problem 25, p. 159

In a SiGe heterojunction transistor, the base contains 10 % germanium, which reduces its bandgap by 9.8 % compared with silicon; the emitter and the collector are pure silicon. Assume that the base current is due only to the holes injected into the emitter, and that the effective densities of states are unchanged.

(a) How does n_i^2 depend on E_g (Chapter 3)? By what factor is n_i^2 of the base larger than that of silicon at 300 K?

(b) Using the formula $I_S = qSD_n n_{iB}^2/(N_B W_B)$, with n_{iB} the intrinsic density of the base, show that β_F is multiplied by $\exp(\Delta E_g/kT)$ compared with an all-silicon transistor of the same doping and geometry.

(c) Compute the ratio of the current gains at 0 °C and at 100 °C. Does the gain increase or decrease with temperature?

(d) Why is this an advantage for the designer? What can be done with the base doping, and which other property of the transistor improves?

(Answer: (a) $n_i^2 \propto \exp(-E_g/kT)$; $\Delta E_g = 0.110$ eV, factor 69; (c) $\beta(0\,°\mathrm{C})/\beta(100\,°\mathrm{C}) = 3.5$, the gain decreases.)